Shipley Proposal Manager

PLAYBOOK™

A Path to Proposal Success





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Shipley Proposal Manager Playbook™

"Every successful professional needs a playbook—a plan to win and outmaneuver the competition. Proposal Managers are no different.

In over 36 years of professional business experience in sales and business development, I can count on one hand how many professionals I've met who have said: "I went to college to become a Proposal Manager." What's your story? The typical story involves being assigned to write or lead proposal efforts, where we learn the hard way—through trial and error.

The Shipley Proposal Manager Playbook™ *includes input from thousands of professionals in dozens of industries and markets, including: business-to-business, business-to-government, international, and non-profit and education.*

I hope this helps in your pursuit to win business."

—Brad Douglas, CEO, Shipley Associates

Understanding the Sales Cycle

Customers buy from people and organizations they trust. You earn customer trust by aligning your sales and capture approach to their buying or acquisition approach. Nobody who plans to buy a car in 30 days wants to be pressured into buying a car on their first visit to the dealer or any online car buying service. At least online, you control most of your buying experience.

Customer buying cycles vary—from online auctions to complex, multi-billion dollar government acquisitions that can last years. In any market or industry, the seller must understand the buyer's process and cycle. A typical sales cycle includes these basic phases:

- The customer identifies a need and seeks products or services to meet that need
- Sales personnel for your company—who sell these products or services—identify an opportunity
- Your sales personnel qualify the opportunity based on your business criteria
- Your sales and capture/opportunity management develop a strategy for competing to win and evolve an opportunity or capture strategy
- You plan, develop, and submit or present a formal or informal proposal
- The customer negotiates the contract terms and awards the contract, and you execute the contract

Adapting the sales approach requires focus and flexibility. At the heart of almost any deal is a proposal–whether written or verbally presented. Regardless of the complexity or value of the sales opportunity, successful organizations manage a sales pipeline with established "go/no-go" decision gates. An opportunity passes through these phases, including proposal planning and proposal development. Complex and high-value proposals require focused attention by a proposal manager who knows how to focus on customer needs and articulates the sales message and value proposition.

Figure 1 below shows the phases of business development and progression of an opportunity through the opportunity lifecycle. Successful organizations tailor these phases to fit their organization and culture and to meet their customers' buying processes.



Figure 1. The Shipley Business Development Lifecycle. *The seven phases are an efficient basis to understand and develop a successful framework for your organization.*

A detailed description of each phase and step in a fundamental business development lifecycle is provided in the *Shipley Business Development Lifecycle Guide.*

The Role of the Bid/Proposal Manager in this Playbook

The proposal manager role varies from organization to organization. Large companies that compete on high-value, complex opportunities often have dedicated proposal managers who oversee all aspects of proposal planning and development, sometimes on multiple proposals at a time. They typically follow an established proposal process as well.

Smaller organizations assign the role of proposal manager to employees capable of managing a solution development and documentation project from inception through submission to the customer. Often, sales or marketing staff are assigned to oversee proposal development with content contributions coming from various technical or subject matter experts. Sometimes the person serving as the proposal manager is also writing a section and coordinating final production as well.

Examples of a proposal manager's tasks include:

- Understanding and carefully documenting customer requirements
- Creating a proposal development schedule and outline
- Leading proposal strategy development
- Conducting a proposal kickoff meeting
- Coordinating proposal solution updates
- Coordinating with assigned writers and editors
- Scheduling reviews during the proposal development cycle
- Ensuring compliance to all requirements
- Ensuring the sales message is consistent and customer focused (focus on customer needs)
- Coordinating approval of the final draft for submission

A typical proposal team structure may look similar to the one shown in Figure 2 below. The team size, titles, and roles will vary from organization to organization.

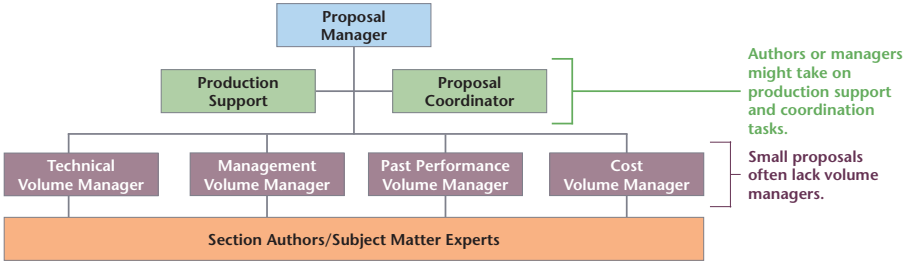


Figure 2. A Sample Proposal Team Structure. *The composition of the team may vary, based on the company and complexity of the pursuit, but someone needs to conduct the activities assigned to the proposal manager.*

No matter the size of the organization, the role of proposal manager is key to successful selling. The written or verbal proposal must reflect the quality and brand of the selling organization. Effective planning, organizing, drafting, and revising are critical steps in developing an effective bid or proposal.

The Proposal Manager Tools

As a proposal manager, you can expect your role to constantly shift as your business and the bidding environment change. You may start in government proposals today only to find that next year you'll focus on international opportunities. Eventually, you might focus on a specific market vertical or business-to-business opportunities.

So, don't get too comfortable. The business and expectations will change.

To be successful, you'll need to be:

- **Flexible:** An ability to adapt to organizational and market shifts
- **Competent:** The know-how to lead and manage by example, using best practices and tools
- **Willing to Learn:** A desire to always improve by learning about new and innovative processes and tools
- **Trusted:** A partner to your team; someone who follows through and delivers results
- **Driven:** A leader who is driven by success with a strong attention to detail—and a passion for winning

This *Playbook* gives you step-by-step instructions and tools on how to successfully move your team forward to producing high-quality, customer-focused proposals. The tools included are simple to use.

Shipley Download Tools & Tips

The following three icons are your guidepost for key milestones, tools to use, and tips throughout the *Playbook*:



Key Milestones: These are critical steps in the management process; be sure to address each of these key steps. At the top of each page is a status bar, showing where you are in the steps leading to a key milestone.



Shipley Download Tools: The titles of tools that are included in the *Playbook* toolkit that apply to the associated step.



Expert Tips: Counsel from experts on how to help you and your team succeed.

How to Maximize the *Playbook*

The *Shipley Proposal Manager Playbook* is a one-stop-shop for the activities, tasks, milestones, and tools to effectively manage a proposal in any market environment—business-to-business, business-to-government, international, and non-profit and education.

The *Playbook* has four primary goals:

1. Enable an effective proposal development process by providing a "how to" approach for proposal managers
2. Improve organizational win rates by leveraging sales activity throughout the proposal process
3. Provide comprehensive, easy-to-use tools to improve proposal efficiencies and save money, time, and resources
4. Win more—improve chances of a sale through execution of a customer-focused sales cycle

The *Playbook* consists of three sections, followed by a glossary of terms and proposal checklists. The *Playbook* also references in-depth information on various topics in the *Shipley Capture Guide* and *Proposal Guide*, and links to a variety of simple Microsoft® Office tools to help accomplish proposal objectives.

Section One: Proposal Planning

Proposal Planning is the phase where you plan how your team will develop a winning proposal before release of a bid request. If you wait until after the bid request is released to begin planning, you divert resources and management focus from preparing a winning proposal. Spend time early developing a solution, formulating a proposal strategy and how to accomplish it, figuring the price to win, recruiting proposal developers, and evaluating past performance, before the release of the final bid request.

Section Two: Proposal Development

Proposal Development is the phase where you prepare a persuasive sales document or presentation. Begin promptly after receiving the bid request and a positive bid validation decision. Carefully plan proposal preparation tasks, make clear individual task assignments, provide coaching where needed, set firm milestone completion dates, and monitor progress daily.

Section Three: Post-Submittal Activities

Post-Submittal Activities are about closing the sale as rapidly as possible so you can begin converting your business development success into revenue and bottom-line profit. Clarify and resolve open items, enter and promptly conclude contract negotiations, and then plan and initiate a smooth transition to product or service delivery.

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Proposal Planning

1

Proposal Planning before writing saves time and effort. In parallel with ongoing sales/ capture planning activities, plan and validate your proposal strategy before you begin writing new material or tailoring reuse material.

1.0 Proposal Planning

The sales and capture team identifies and qualifies opportunities worthy of proposal planning. An opportunity win strategy should be established as proposal planning activity begins.

Focus on five proposal planning activities:



Win Strategy

Based on sound selling activity, an opportunity win strategy should include ways to:

- Leverage your strengths
- Mitigate your weaknesses
- Neutralize your competitors' strengths
- Exploit your competitors' weaknesses

Having a sound opportunity win strategy streamlines the proposal management process.

1-1 Continue customer contacts from the Opportunity or Capture Plan

The handoff from a sales/capture activity to the proposal planning activity does not terminate the former activities. Sales/capture personnel can still influence the customer while you plan the proposal, especially since the final bid request is not available yet. Therefore, the activities at the start of the Proposal Planning phase are connected with the sales/capture activities.

1

Continue customer contacts and intelligence gathering.

2

Marketing, technical, and management resources might be involved in site visits coordinated by the opportunity owner.

Use these visits to better understand the customer's needs, most important issues, and views on potential solutions and requirements.

3

Offer expert technical and program assistance to help the customer value alternative solutions and refine requirements before the final bid request is issued.

Your objective is to influence the customer to prefer your solution and organization.

1-2 Develop proposal strategy

Extend the win strategy from your opportunity/capture plan into the proposal strategy. Proposal strategy consists of a series of statements that emphasize your point or value proposition and how you plan to make that point in your proposal.

Review the bidder comparison matrix and win strategies that were developed during the opportunity/capture planning stage. If an opportunity/capture plan is not available, work with your management team to develop win strategies and then prepare and review a bidder comparison matrix.

Translate win strategy statements into proposal strategy statements, then assign each statement to one or more proposal sections via the writers' packages (see Figure 3 below).

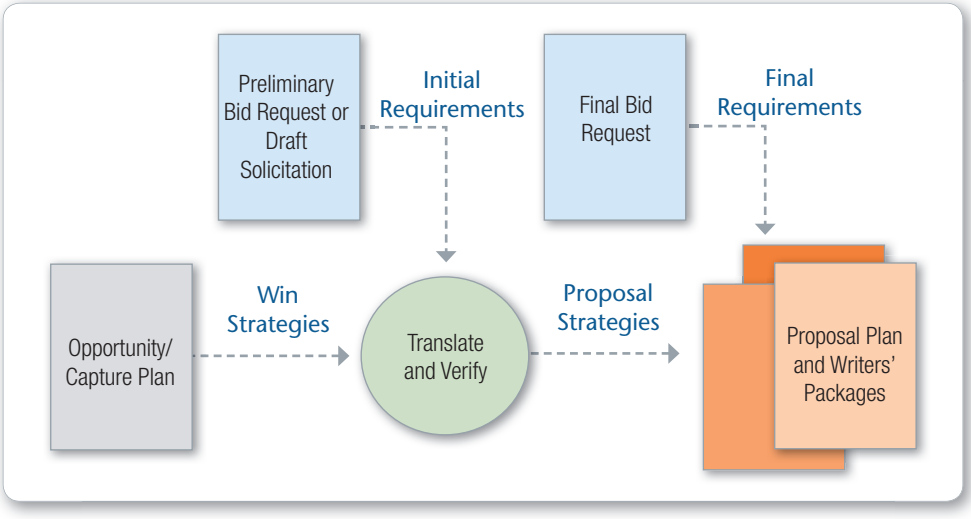


Figure 3. Translate Win Strategies into Proposal Strategies. *Compare the opportunity/capture plan, draft solicitation, and (later) the final solicitation to see if the customer's requirements have changed, and that your assumptions remain correct.*

For example, a win strategy that emphasizes one of your strengths may be relevant personnel experience. To convert this into a proposal strategy, you may state that the customer will reduce program risk through your personnel that have implemented and managed the same program for other clients.

Strategy Statement Template
Integrated Solution Worksheet
Bidder Comparison Matrix

See Strategy and Storyboards and Mockups in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-3 Define proposal tasks, budget, and schedule

As you develop your schedule, consider the amount of time you anticipate needing to develop the proposal itself. Figure 4 below shows major milestones associated with proposal development, regardless of duration or complexity.

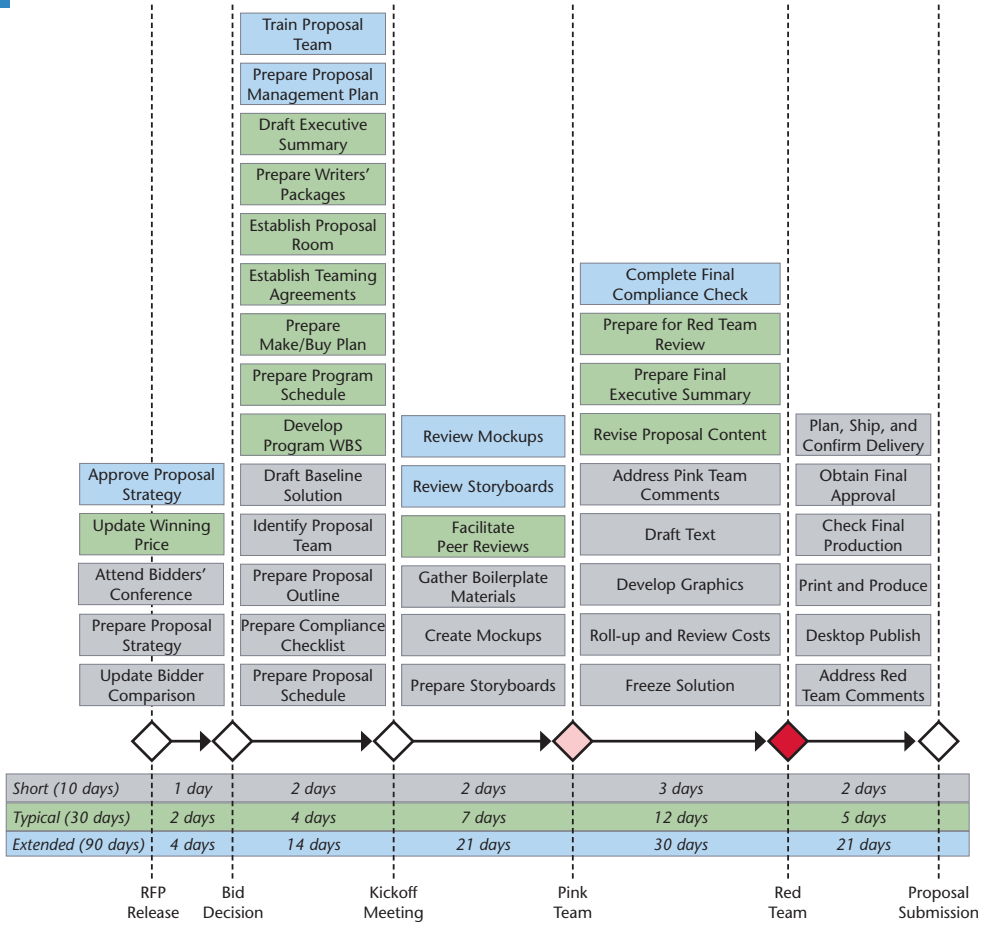


Figure 4. Select Tasks Based on Your Available Time. *Use the schedule above as guidance when deciding on tasks and timing for proposal efforts. The shortest schedules, such as for task order responses, must include essential tasks. More typical schedules add additional reviews, more tasks related to the proposed program, and additional revisions. Extended schedules, often for large-system acquisitions, may require proposal team training, detailed strategy approvals, and more interim reviews.*

Proposal managers develop the proposal project schedule to manage proposal contributors within a defined process. Proposal managers, core team members, and section writers use the schedule to manage themselves and others.

Deadlines drive proposal schedules, with surprisingly minimal influence from the size of the tasks. When tasks are larger, adjust team resources accordingly. The guidelines below summarize key recommendations for the proposal manager.

Schedule backwards	Schedule proposal submission first. Next, schedule key milestones. Adjust timing as tasks are added.
Reserve contingency time	Allow time for unanticipated problems.
Maximize parallel tasks	Avoid bottlenecks by scheduling many tasks simultaneously.
Estimate realistically	Use time standards in Figure 5—or those developed within your organization—to ensure adequate time is allowed for critical tasks.
Resource optimally	Conserve budget by assigning start and end dates for each task. Avoid assigning personnel for the duration of the proposal to minimize resource costs.
Use standard work periods	Except on very short schedules, leave weekends and holidays free. These days may be needed later for contingency time.
Plan for production	Do not force the production staff to absorb others' delays.
Plan for reviews	Allow adequate time to complete reviews and incorporate comments.
Manage to the schedule	Develop recovery plans whenever task completions slip.



Shipley Blank 30-Day Schedule
Shipley Blank 45-Day Schedule

See Production, Proposal Management Plan, and Scheduling in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

Develop estimating standard metrics for your company to estimate proposal development time. These metrics will improve productivity as contributors strive to meet your internal standards. Figure 5 below shows metrics one company uses to estimate proposal development time.

Task	Time Standard
Write new material	*4 pages per day*
Revise text or edit for content	*8-10 pages per day*
Proofreading	*20-25 pages per day*
Create/revise simple graphic	*2 hours*
Create/revise medium complex graphic	*4 hours*
Create/revise complex graphic	*6 hours*
Participate in Red Team	*40 pages per day*
Desktop publishing	*70-100 pages per day*

(Source: APMP Foundations Study Guide)

Figure 5. Set Metrics to Help Develop Your Schedule. *As an estimate, time to complete the tasks varies based on complexity, resource capability, and the tools used to develop proposals. Develop your own metrics based on the resources you have available in your organization.*

1-4 Review and approve proposal strategy, pricing, and cost

Collaboration among business development, sales, marketing, and the proposal team is critical to proposal success—and essential to creating a healthy proposal environment.

Gather an independent team of people, including managers, to review, validate, and suggest improvements to your proposal strategy. Ask them to review your technical, management, teaming, and pricing solution against the customer's needs and requirements, alignment with the win strategy, and competitive focus.



The sales or capture strategy must be clearly communicated to those contributing to the proposal. Get concurrence from your management on the strategy, and then communicate the strategy with your proposal team during your kickoff meeting (Section 1-23).

See Reviews in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-5 Establish team area and library

All organizations are unique in size, complexity, and sophistication in supporting proposal development. Regardless of your situation, establish a central place (physical or digital) for managing the proposal effort.

Proposal teams need space to work. Physical proposal rooms often called "war rooms," offer significant collaboration advantages. When managers, writers, editors, and graphic artists work together, an esprit de corps develops. Developing a consistent style and tone is easier, coordination is easier, quality improves, and revisions are reduced.

However, virtual or partially virtual proposal teams are increasingly common and necessary. Virtual teams are more flexible to form, execute, and disband; better talent often becomes available; logistics costs might be reduced; and response time is reduced by eliminating travel time. Extra communication is a must for virtual teams.

If all or substantial portions of your proposal team work remotely, seek virtual equivalents to your usual co-located team management approaches.

Consider how team members will meet, obtain library information, collaborate, share drafts, and work with support personnel.

Be conscious of company and facility security requirements, and identify appropriate instructions for team participants regarding security.

Begin preparing for proposal production. Even at this early stage, you want to establish expectations for proposal production quality. Decide how the proposal will be produced as the process will affect schedules, timelines, and how the proposal is written.



Expert Tip

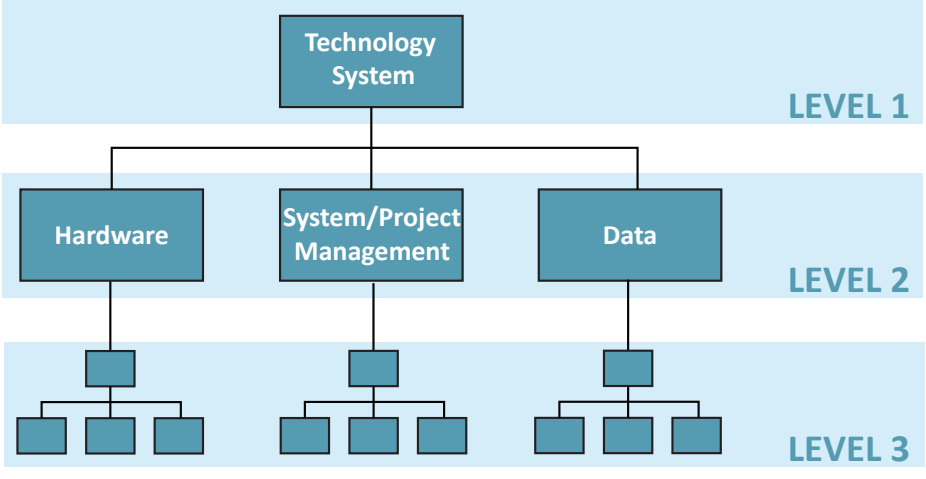
Tips for virtual teams:

- Establish and maintain a high-trust environment
- Set a pattern of frequent and clear communication for the team
- Define and assign clear roles
- Define clear and discrete tasks
- Establish ground rules for virtual meetings
- Establish and follow a rigorous review schedule

1-6 Develop a draft Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) and WBS Dictionary

The proposal manager should designate a team member to begin developing the Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) and WBS dictionary. The WBS identifies and links the hardware, services, and data elements of your solution to the customer's needs. The WBS dictionary defines the hardware, service, and data elements.

If the bid request lacks a WBS, build one, similar to the one shown in Figure 6 below. Customers often include a WBS to more easily compare offerors' solutions. Use the customer's WBS, if possible, or plan to justify your deviations.



"A WBS organizes, defines, and displays the product to be developed or produced and relates the elements of work to be accomplished to each other and to the end product."

- **Applicable to large or small systems**
- **Required for most proposals**
- **Provides a framework for cost and progress reporting and for management**

Figure 6. WBS Sample in Tree View. *The WBS relates the elements of work to be accomplished to each other and to the end product. The WBS can be built in a tree structure, as above, or in a variety of other layouts, such as an outline, a table, or a hierarchical view.*

For proposals requiring a WBS, it is normally included in the technical, management, and cost volumes or sections.

1-7 Receive the program/project schedule from the program or technical team

The program or technical team develops a master program/project schedule from the draft solicitation, preliminary bid request, or prior intelligence.



The schedule shows the timing of each project task. Writers, estimators, and other contributors need a project schedule to determine task sequence and to place the cost estimates and other information in the appropriate time period.

If the bid request requires an Integrated Master Plan (IMP) and Integrated Master Schedule (IMS), identify and assign a specialist for this complex task.

A program/project plan provides the "big picture" of the overall execution of the opportunity. This plan gives high-level insight into the timelines, sequence, and effort necessary for pursuing the opportunity.

You will develop a specific Proposal Management Plan (PMP) later to lay out the proposal development process and schedule (see Section 1-11).

1-8 Initiate detailed make/buy plan

Your management initiates the detailed make/buy plan for distribution to the proposal team. Your make/buy decisions impact who describes, costs, and prices the task.

Make/buy and teaming considerations are inseparable. Customers often impose work share requirements, such as small, minority, or disadvantaged business percentages.

Consider these make/buy questions:

? Which production or service delivery facility is most competitive, produces the best quality, and has the capacity?

? Do you or a vendor have necessary tooling, production equipment, management systems, and trained personnel available?

? Can you tie this to another program to reduce costs?

? Have you made the product or delivered this service before? What is our past performance record? Can it be verified?

? Can you design, develop, and test your software solution better than what currently exists?

1-9 Validate that in-house, subcontractor, and/or teaming Statements of Work (SOWs) are being developed by your company

Teaming or subcontractor plans must be solid and sound to protect all parties participating in the proposal and in the subsequent contract. The contracts manager supervises the development of the in-house, subcontractor, or teaming SOWs. The proposal manager is aware of these activities to ensure the proposal response addresses the team's composition and capability.

1

Company management supervises the development of the in-house, subcontractor, or teaming SOWs. Assign an experienced contracts manager to prepare the teaming SOW, as subcontractors will vie for maximum work shares, often seeking written commitments.

2

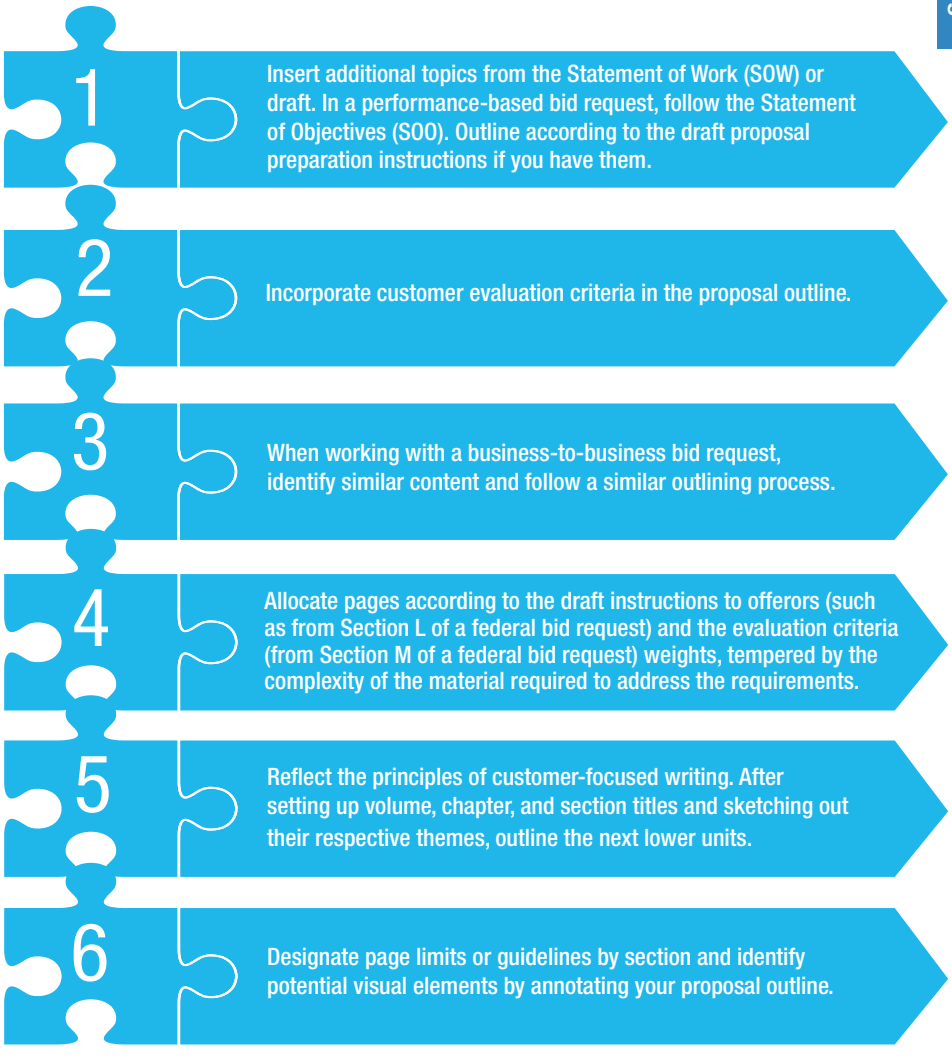
Identify each task, describe what will be done, and who will be responsible to manage and complete the task. The overriding principle is to include all tasks, eliminate overlapping tasks, and define the interfaces among tasks. If not, you will either over- or under-cost tasks and damage your credibility with the customer. Overlapping tasks leads to double costing and defective pricing.

3

Prepare a subcontractor and/or teaming SOW based on the preliminary make/buy decision, draft WBS, program schedule, and in-house SOW. The subcontractor/teaming SOW defines the tasks and responsibilities of the subcontractors or team members. Early issuance of a detailed subcontractor/teaming SOW will save time, later (when time is short) and make the complete offer more competitive.

1-10 Develop initial proposal outline

Adjust how you prepare the proposal outline depending upon the availability of customer guidelines. Find a home within that framework for the requirements in other bid request sections.



Note: On U.S. Government proposals, a specific section in the bid request includes detailed instructions on how to organize the proposal. Follow those instructions.

Shipley Proposal Outline and Status Tracker

See Outlining, Storyboards and Mockups, and Customer Focus in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

If a preliminary bid request is not going to be issued, and this is a strategic pursuit, draft a strawman solicitation. Base your strawman solicitation on previous bid requests for similar projects issued by the same organization. Add technical, management, and cost information from intelligence gathered during opportunity/capture planning. The items listed below can help you shape your proposal outline.

Proposal organization instructions. Develop an overall topical outline and approximate page limits.

Evaluation criteria. Rank and weight probable evaluation criteria. Use the weights to approximate the page allocation by topic.

Statement of Work (SOW). List and briefly describe probable work tasks, deliverables, and data requirements. Integrate information from prior bid requests and customer visits or web posts.

Contract line items that must be priced. Typically, contract line items are listed at a higher level than the tasks and deliverables described in the SOW.

1-11 Establish a Proposal Management Plan

The Proposal Management Plan (PMP) includes the elements to manage proposal development and guide contributors. The content, form, and medium vary by proposal, organization, process, and resources. Formal, document-based proposal management plans are increasingly developed within collaborative web applications and then shared and updated on secure intranet sites. The PMP is best created and maintained as separate artifacts stored in a common location.

A PMP typically consists of:

- Customer Profile and key issues assigned to customer decision makers
- Competitive Analysis
- Proposal Strategies and Themes
- Staffing Roles and Responsibilities
- Defined Proposal Operations
- Type of Contract

A PMP's attachments may consist of:

- Proposal Schedule
- Proposal Outline
- Writers' Information
- Proposal Strategy
- Executive Summary
- WBS and WBS Dictionary
- Team Contact List
- File Repository
- Printer Locations
- Building/Room Security Restrictions

Keep the PMP current and complete:

- Give the team the big picture
- Keep management and contributors current on daily progress
- Convey daily tasks, expectations, and quality standards
- Expose contributors to the same information while reducing misleading rumors

See Proposal Management Plan in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

Once the overall framework for the proposal has been developed, the core team can begin to assemble boilerplate or re-use material. Do not wait for the bid request to arrive to do this because many items (such as legal clearance and certifications and representations) can be validated at this point by management and legal staff.

Assemble the following items before the solicitation arrives:

- Organizational charts of the bidding organizations and the solution or technical team
- Flow diagrams of relevant processes
- Résumés of named individuals filling key positions
- Descriptions of relevant facilities
- Relevant experience descriptions, quantified performance data, and potential references

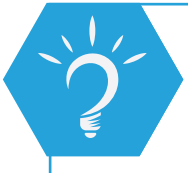
1-12 Support customer definition of needs and requirements

The proposal manager functions best when informed of the customer's core issues that are driving the opportunity. Seek this information from the sales/opportunity and capture personnel.

The solution team and technical staff will craft a solution that supports customer needs and requirements. The proposal manager counsels them on how to identify all customer needs, hot button issues, and requirements.

A "hot button" is a need, worry, or issue underlying the customer's decision to buy.

The proposal manager guides the solution team on how to explicitly discuss compliance and responsiveness implications of alternate solutions. Evaluators will check compliance, so deviations must be justified and made an explicit part of your capture and proposal strategy.



Expert Tip

As a proposal manager, always probe for hidden customer issues that need to be addressed in the proposal, including:

- Political issues
- Personal agendas
- Biases

See Outlining, and Storyboards and Mockups in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-13 Define detailed baseline offering

Initiate the baseline solution as early as possible and work toward an early solution freeze. A comprehensive baseline solution includes the technical, management, and pricing solution. Focusing exclusively on the technical solution often leads to an overly elaborate technical solution that is more costly and less competitive.

- ✓ Seek an early freeze of the solution framework
- ✓ Enable contributors to persuasively describe the solution in storyboards and section drafts
- ✓ Help authors and subject matter experts begin articulating the benefits of the solution features
- ✓ Enforce solution change decision gates to minimize re-work
- ✓ Consider competitors' likely solutions

"The most costly aspect of proposal development can be re-work caused by undisciplined changes in the baseline solution to the customer."

—Steve Shipley, Chairman, Shipley Associates



Integrated Solution Worksheet

 See Engaging Program Support, and Pricing to Win in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

1-14 Receive, review, and comment on preliminary solicitation

Demonstrate your interest and understanding of the customer and its needs by reviewing the preliminary bid request and making constructive suggestions for improvement, where possible. The preliminary bid request may include Requests for Information (RFI) or other industry calls.

Consider other reasons to respond to preliminary solicitation requests:



Follow these guidelines when responding to preliminary bid request documents:

- ✓ Make the core proposal team responsible for analyzing the document and formulating the formal response to it
- ✓ Have contributors assess the technical, management, and cost elements
- ✓ Draw on specialists in the functional areas—for detailed inputs to the preliminary solicitation
- ✓ Avoid requesting general clarification of the requirements; ask specific questions and make specific recommendations
- ✓ Discuss the benefits to the customer for each of the recommended changes to the solicitation

See Model Documents in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-15 Update winning price window

Based on the intelligence collected, check that the cost team is updating the price to win. The price to win must 1) be within the winning price window, 2) be capable of winning, and 3) project adequate return on investment for the opportunity. Figure 7 below shows that updating the winning price window which aligns the customer budget with your ability to deliver takes time and competitive insight.

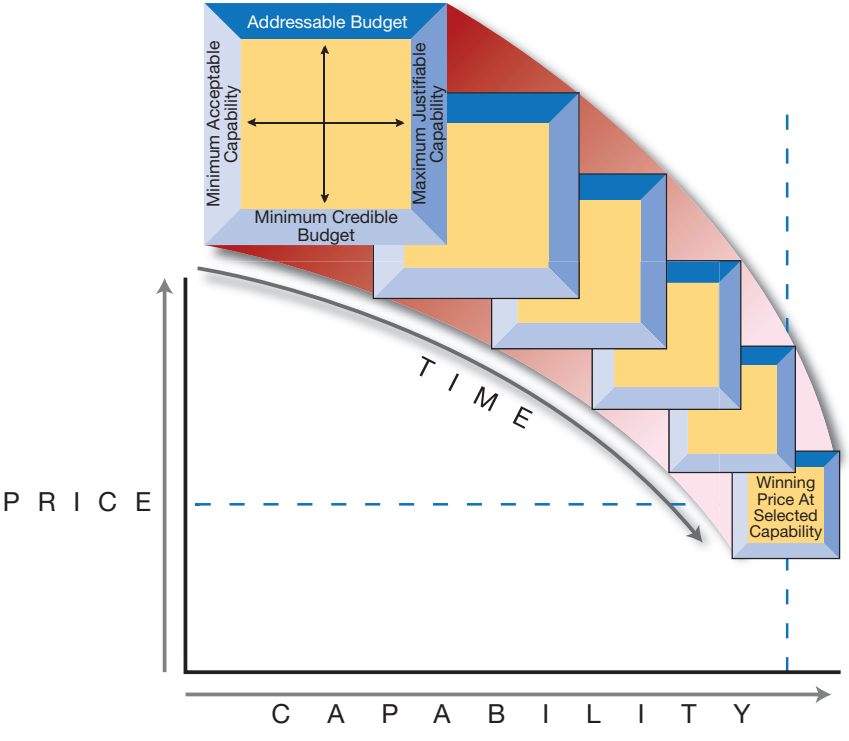


Figure 7. Contribute to Developing the Winning Price. *While the proposal manager doesn't own this process, the proposal manager can ensure that the cost team has the latest information on strategy and solution to keep the processes aligned.*

1-16 Check with the cost team to track cost drivers and their update of the target price in competitive range

Costing in support of the targeted price to win is complex and, if not done well, can sink the pursuit. Normally, the objective is to minimize or balance price against capability. Therefore, cost drivers need to be identified early to improve your flexibility in achieving the price to win. The actual cost estimating activity starts in step 1-19.

The cost team should consider the following costing and pricing relationships and issues:

- ✓ Costing must be done top-down and bottom-up
  - — Top-down costing can be based on the customer's known budget or parametrics from a prior, similar program
  - — Bottom-up costing often leads to over-costing, as safety factors are added at each level by multiple individuals
- ✓ Price targets are influenced by competitors' probable pricing strategies; approaches that result in a cost below the targeted price are preferable

See Costing and Pricing to Win in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

1-17 Identify writing and reviewing assignments for proposal team members

Work with company management to identify proposal team members. Then identify individual assignments and when the team members will be involved. Notify team members and their immediate supervisors. Ideally, the proposal manager notifies members of their assignments personally, depending upon the size of the proposal team and the location of members. A typical team for a proposal is shown in Figure 8 below.

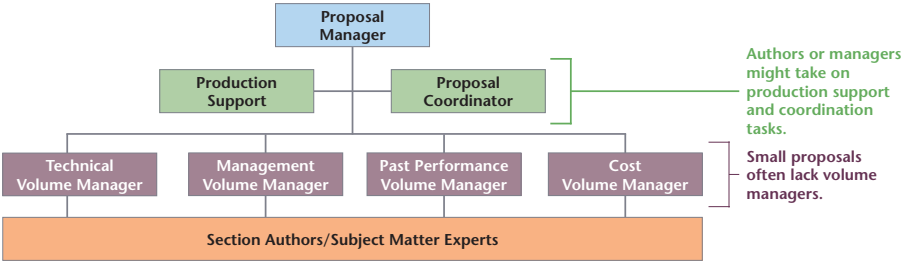


Figure 8. Roles on a Typical Proposal Team. *Build the team based on the size and complexity of your potential bid, but seek to define and assign discrete roles and tasks to complete the required proposal efforts.*

Proposal teams vary in size and make-up based on the size of the organization and the value and complexity of the opportunity.

A proposal manager must know what resources are available to support the proposal as early as possible.

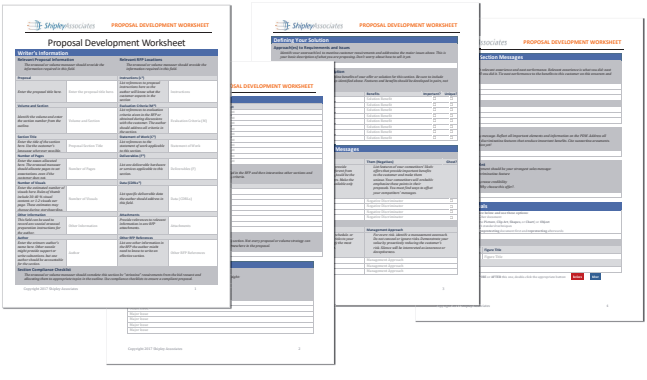
1-18 Initiate preparation of storyboards or Proposal Development Worksheets (PDWs)

The proposal manager and other proposal contributors initiate storyboards, such as Proposal Development Worksheets (PDWs), to guide proposal writers. Proposal management completes as many of the storyboards as possible to clearly define writers' assignments:

- Section title and number
- Author's name
- Page allocation
- Compliance checklist
- Section outline
- Customer issues
- Past performance
- Proposal strategy applicable to the author's section

Other guidance may include:

- Technical solutions
- Suggested themes
- Features and benefits
- Suggested graphics
- Risk management or mitigation approach



Proposal tools, including storyboards and PDWs, save time and improve quality when adapted and managed to the effort. Tools can be individual documents or can be part of a software suite.

Proposal Development Worksheet
Proposal Section Planner
Proposal Section Organizer

See Storyboards and Mockups in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-19 Prepare estimating guidelines

Task the cost leader to establish cost estimating guidelines for estimators. Estimating guidelines enhance the consistency of estimates, estimating rationale improves, and contract negotiations will be faster and less contentious. Have the team prepare estimating guidelines and assumptions, and insert them into the cost proposal.

Include the following in your estimating guidelines:

- ✓ Level of WBS to which proposal costs will be estimated and submitted
- ✓ In-house SOW or extended WBS and WBS dictionary
- ✓ WBS/SOW/Functional Responsibility matrix
- ✓ List of relevant jobs and historic costs
- ✓ Make/buy determination
- ✓ Program schedules with dictated milestones
- ✓ List of the quality and type of hardware required
- ✓ Whether cost/schedule reports are required (DoD 7000.2 reports)
- ✓ Deliverables list
- ✓ Relevant financial ground rules, such as escalation, facility capitalization, facilities and location of work, rates, etc.
- ✓ Other relevant baseline data

Shipley Project Basis of Estimate Template

1-20 Create a SOW/WBS/BOE responsibility matrix

To ensure compliance to customer requirements, a proposal manager oversees the creation of a responsibility matrix that includes all necessary information.

In the proposal, all SOW tasks and contract line items must be tied to the WBS.

The cost lead assigns a cost team member to create a Basis of Estimate (BOE) responsibility matrix using the bid request, the WBS, contract deliverables, and contract line items, if appropriate, to identify department responsibility by task.

Prepare a SOW/WBS cross-reference matrix to ensure they are parallel and to help ensure compatibility among the technical, management, and cost volumes. The SOW/WBS responsibility matrix can also be used as a checklist to ensure all bid request requirements are addressed.



See Compliance and Responsiveness in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-21 Prepare writers' packages and direct the gathering of re-use or boilerplate materials

Proposal managers and volume managers or leads ensure that section writers understand their assignments and the specific tasks they are expected to accomplish. Based on the draft or strawman solicitation and your Proposal Management Plan (PMP), create writers' packages that include:

Author assignments

Guidelines on graphics and action captions

Assigned section numbers

Proposal baseline solution

Page allocations

Compliance checklists

Customer issues

Features and benefits

Strategy at the proposal, volume, and section levels

Themes

Discriminators

Proposal style sheet

Draft executive summary

Proposal development schedule

Guidelines on how the bases of estimates will be accomplished

Team organization chart and roster listing each contributor, organization, and contact information

Writers' standards, guidelines, and sources of support

1-22 Draft an executive summary

A draft proposal executive summary provides a roadmap for the proposal manager and team regarding potential sales messages and alignment with customer objectives. It should include key win themes that will be integrated into the proposal message.

1

Either the opportunity manager or the sales manager prepares a full draft of the executive summary. While the opportunity manager "owns" the executive summary, the assigned author varies depending upon the organization, customer understanding, and relative skills and availability of the opportunity team members.

2

The draft executive summary might not resemble the final version, but the preparation process helps you refine your proposal strategy, communicates that strategy in-house to all contributors, and models how your proposal will look.

Have the executive summary written first, edit it repeatedly, and revise it for the last time just before proposal production.



Executive Summary Organizer
Executive Summary Planning Worksheet

1-23 Hold proposal kickoff meeting

Proposal kickoff meetings represent a key milestone for the proposal manager. An effective proposal kickoff meeting can align the understanding of the proposal team and all contributors and reviewers regarding the opportunity (strategy and content) and the development schedule proposal (process).

As a culmination of the core team's preparation, hold the proposal kickoff meeting. Finalize the kickoff materials with the opportunity lead before the meeting. During the meeting, use the draft PMP to explain and create understanding of the following proposal items:

- Summary of the opportunity
- Anomalies in the bid request
- Win strategy
- Baseline design of the offering/solution
- Proposal format
- Proposal schedule and overview schedule
- Writer assignment
- Security controls
- Document storage site
- Document version control
- Publication operations

Have the opportunity lead present the customer background and the strategy on how to win.

Invite:

- All members of the core team, including writers, editors, desktop publishers, subject matter experts
- Key management, including those who have made and will make critical decisions on this proposal effort
- Key marketers and business developers
- Key technical contributors
- Color team reviewers, if known
- Selected members of the extended proposal team, including subcontractors

Goals of the proposal kickoff meeting are shown below.



Kickoff Meeting Checklist

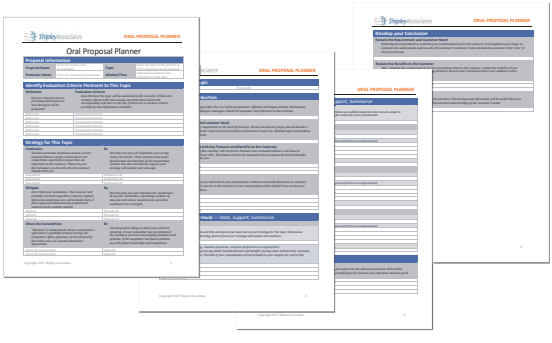
1-24 Complete and review storyboards; prepare mockups/Oral Proposal Planners (OPPs)

Proposal contributors should be trained on the purpose and use of storyboards and other tools that will be employed during proposal and oral presentation development.

You can accelerate development of one storyboard as a model for what is expected in terms of focus of each section and the level of detail. You could also show an example from a prior proposal, if a good example is available.

Use Proposal Development Worksheets (PDWs)/storyboards and mockups to plan, develop, and review new content for proposal sections before writing text. Use them to save time and improve quality.

PDWs have a one-to-one relationship with major sections of the proposal pertaining to a common topic. PDWs list writers' assignments, bid request requirements, strategies, features, benefits, discriminators, preliminary visuals, and content in bullet list form.



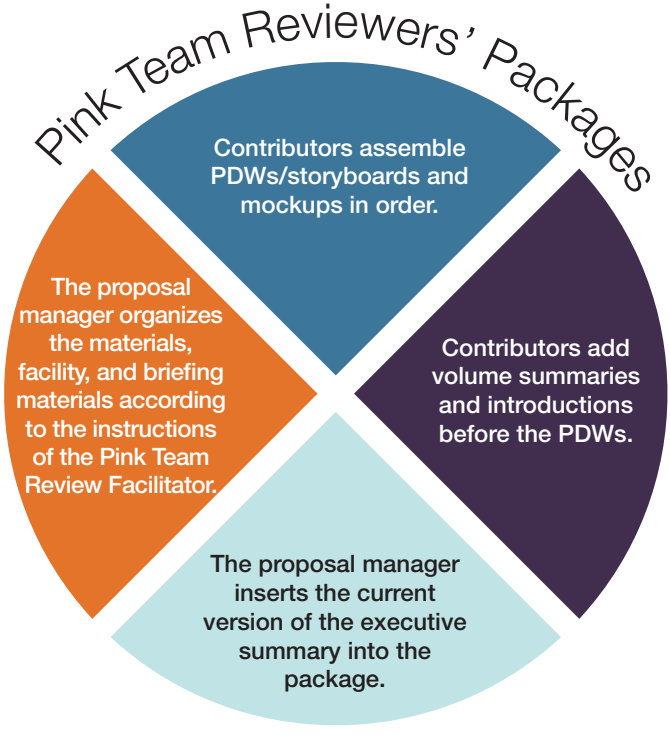
The Oral Proposal Planner (OPP) is a variant of a PDW used to help contributors plan an oral proposal.

- Mockup Template
- Proposal Development Worksheet
- Proposal Section Planner
- Proposal Section Organizer
- Orals Development Checklist
- Oral Proposal Planner

1-25 Hold peer review and prepare materials for Pink Team

Determine what you will review at your Pink Team (see section 1-26). Some proposal managers schedule more than one Pink Team review for different proposal sections or volumes. In general, review only PDWs/storyboards and mockups at the first Pink Team review; review drafts in subsequent Pink Team reviews after receiving the final bid request.

Where feasible, peer reviews are scheduled before color team reviews, especially the Pink Team review. Ask contributors to review and make constructive recommendations for improvements to materials prepared by their peers. Implement constructive suggestions and prepare the materials for the Pink Team review. The proposal manager participates in these reviews as well, looking to validate compliance, strengthen themes and discriminators, and evaluate graphics ideas.



Pink Team Instructions
Pink Team Planner

1-26 Hold Pink Team review, including cost volume and initial bottom-up cost estimate

Hold a Pink Team review to ensure:

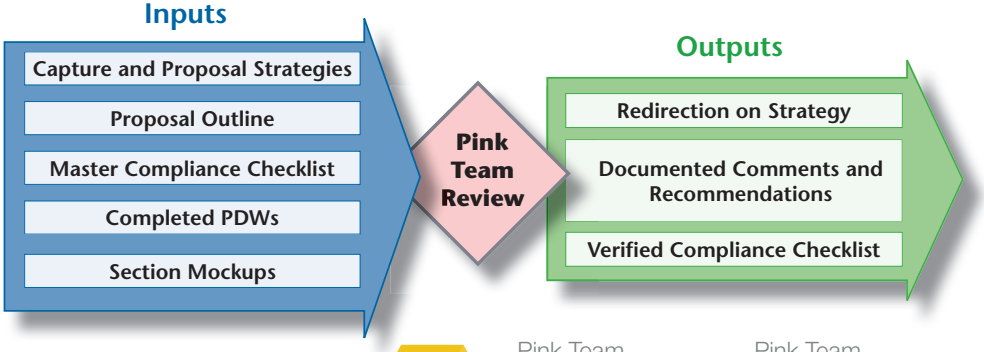
- Compliance with the customer's requirements
- Implementation of agreed-upon strategy
- Consistency of volumes

A major issue with color team reviews, including the Pink Team review, is securing knowledgeable, skilled, experienced, and constructive reviewers. Skilled reviewers are invariably over scheduled, so set a date in the proposal schedule well in advance of the review date to identify, invite, and confirm reviewers' participation.

For a co-located review team, post PDWs and mockups on walls or panels. For a virtual team, distribute instructions and content electronically or on a collaboration site. These pages reveal the proposal's structure, compliance, responsiveness, strategy, and competitive focus. The Pink Team reviews and critiques the posted content for:

- Compliance
- Strategy
- Visuals
- Themes
- Space allocation
- Organizational compliance with the proposal outline
- Overall cohesiveness

For cost volumes and estimates, the reviewers can check progress toward requirements at this stage and provide guidance on cost drivers and strategy.



Pink Team Assessment Form

Pink Team In-briefing Template

Pink Team Review Form

See Oral Proposals and Storyboards and Mockups in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-27 Update PDWs/storyboards and mockups/ OPPs in response to Pink Team

The Pink Team debriefs the core proposal team. The core team (with section leaders and writers where necessary) reviews Pink Team recommendations, decides which recommendations are valid, revises the proposal strategy, and tasks volume managers to direct revisions to the PDWs/storyboards and mockups.

Pink Team Objectives

- Alignment with the proposal strategy
- Alignment among sections
- Clarity and specificity
- Links to experience and performance examples

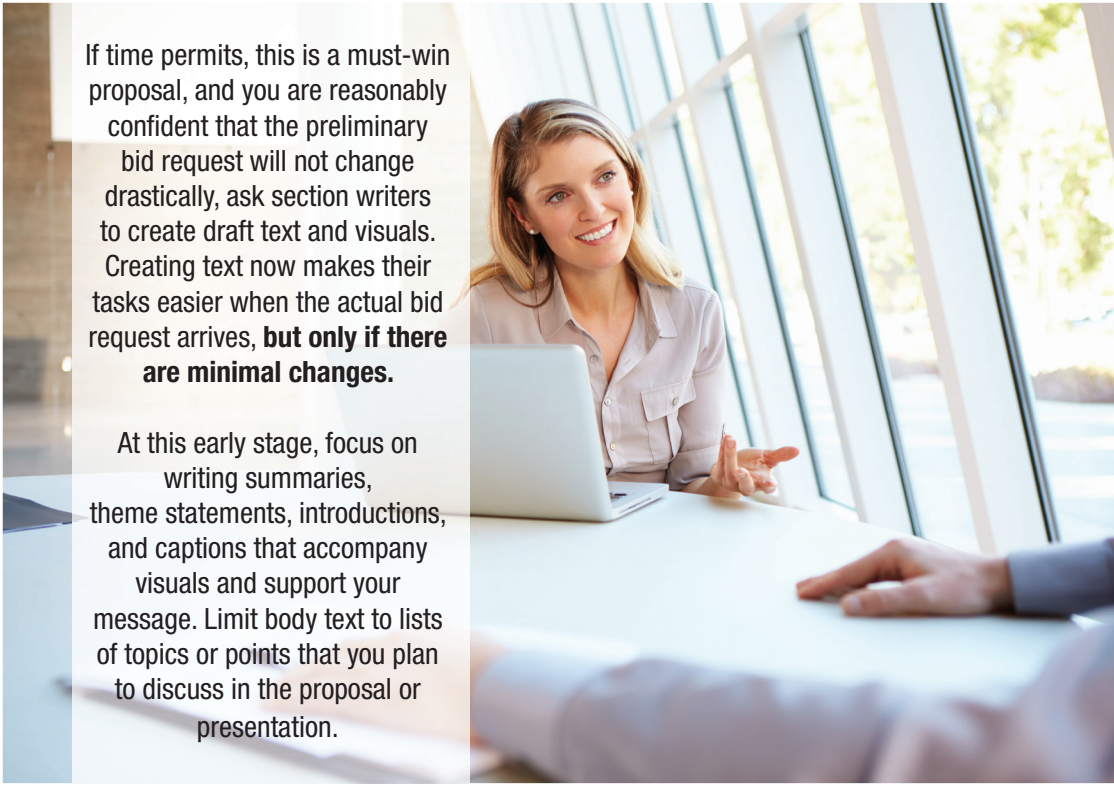
Those sections that scored well during Pink Team should be given a green light to begin writing. Sections with issues need to be corrected and approved before starting the writing process.



Pink Team Out-briefing Template

1-28 Begin early draft content

The proposal manager provides guidance to team members assigned to draft content. Instruct them to be clear and concise in their writing, focusing on customer benefits and the solution features that provide these benefits.



If time permits, this is a must-win proposal, and you are reasonably confident that the preliminary bid request will not change drastically, ask section writers to create draft text and visuals. Creating text now makes their tasks easier when the actual bid request arrives, **but only if there are minimal changes.**

At this early stage, focus on writing summaries, theme statements, introductions, and captions that accompany visuals and support your message. Limit body text to lists of topics or points that you plan to discuss in the proposal or presentation.

See Storyboards and Mockups in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

1-29 Receive and analyze customer solicitation

The proposal manager must thoroughly read the solicitation documents and be accountable for compliance and responsiveness. In addition, direct your volume leads, and perhaps the proposal coordinator, to also analyze the final bid request.

Read the bid request several times. Skim the bid request to get a feel for the entire document. Gain an overall understanding of the bid request and procurement. If possible, let an entire day pass before your next detailed review.

Take extensive notes. Identify areas where the bid request is vague, confusing, or inconsistent. Discuss these parts with your core team. Formulate questions for clarification to ask the customer.

Look for these common types of requirements:

- ✓ Customer needs/problems
- ✓ Technical performance or operational specifications
- ✓ Deliverables, including contractual deliverables
- ✓ Due dates for questions as well as proposal submittals
- ✓ Proposal requirements/format/organization
- ✓ Evaluation criteria

When possible, also link requirements with customer hot button issues.

1-30 Prepare final bid/no-bid recommendation

When the customer issues the final bid request, your company needs to validate your bid decision. Identify exactly what senior managers expect to be presented at a Bid Validation Decision Gate review.

Work with the core opportunity/capture team to prepare and present the final bid/no-bid recommendation for this review.

Consider the following questions:

Bid Request Analysis	*Are announced bid request terms as anticipated and still acceptable?* *Does the bid request show evidence of influence by competitors?* *Based on published evaluation criteria, can the customer justify selecting us?*
Solution	*Are technical requirements in the bid request what we anticipated?* *Is our technical approach verified as acceptable to the customer?* *Are teammate roles clearly defined and formally agreed?*
Proposal Readiness	*Are the proposal schedule, budget, outline, and compliance checklist complete?* *Is the proposal team identified?* *Has a draft executive summary been prepared?* *Has the price to win been updated based on the latest competitive intelligence and bid request?* *Is our preliminary, bottom-up cost estimate consistent with the price to win?* *Can the solution be profitably delivered at the price to win?*
Issues	*Have all our internal issues been addressed and resolved?* *Are there requirements or evaluation factors that cause gaps in our win strategy or proposed solution that we cannot overcome in the time available?* *Can/will we devote the resources needed to develop a winning proposal within the available schedule?* *Have we completed sufficient preparation to write a high-quality proposal within the available schedule?*

See Decision Gate Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

1-31 Review and validate the bid decision

In this gate review, the core opportunity/capture team presents the prepared materials. Figure 9 below shows guidelines for reviewing and validating the bid decision.

Decisions	• Continue proposal development • Confirm/adjust win strategy, solution, price to win • Adjust funding for remaining proposal development activities • Address any new risks
Attendees	• Executive personnel • Operations • Business development manager • Capture/Opportunity manager (supported by the proposal manager)
Inputs	• Updated opportunity/capture plan • Final bid request • Proposal plan • Current strategy, solution, and price • Recommendations for the way forward
Resources Allocated	• Full proposal team and funding • Review teams and funding

Figure 9. Guidelines for Bid Validation Decision. *At the Bid Validation Decision gate, your executives confirm the earlier Preliminary Bid Decision after considering whether requirements, solution, pricing, schedule, competition, and other factors still present a favorable picture. An affirmative decision moves you out of proposal planning and fully into proposal development.*

End the pursuit of opportunities that you are unlikely to win, saving half or more of the business development costs associated with the opportunity.

Proposal Development

Resist the urge to hold a proposal update kickoff meeting until you can clarify the contributor assignments. Instead, review your process, finalize your plan and schedule, and conduct an effective kickoff meeting when you are ready.



Notes:

2.0 Proposal Development

Proposal development should begin immediately after receiving the bid request and a positive bid validation decision. Carefully review proposal preparation tasks, clarify individual task assignments, set firm milestone completion dates, and monitor progress daily. Reduce preparation time by working in parallel.

Focus on four key proposal development activities:

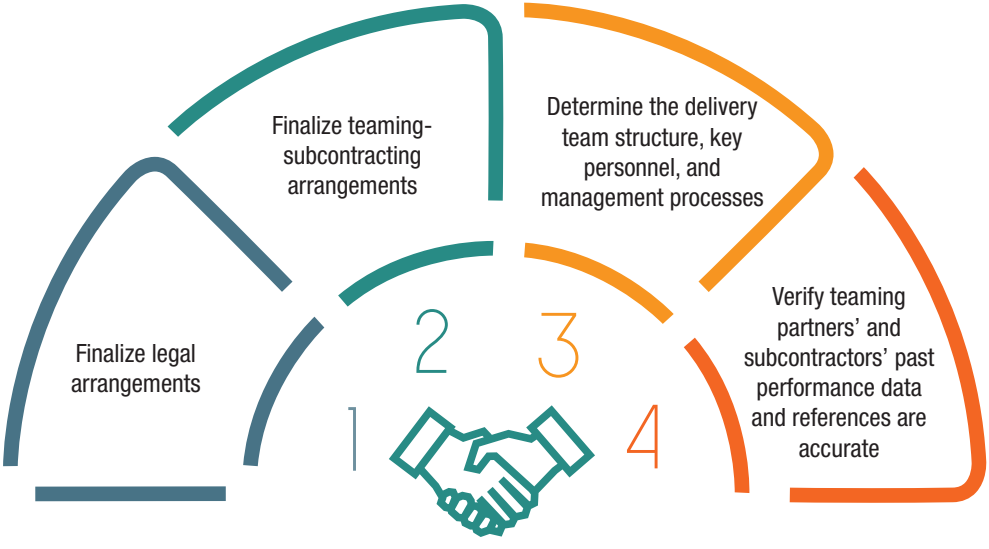


The proposal development team needs a clear vision and understanding of the overall proposal strategy and plan.

See Compliance and Responsiveness and Outlining in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

2-1 Finalize team and subcontractor relationships

Ideally, your management or contracts team will have negotiated an exclusive relationship with subcontractors. Always share information carefully. Balance your need to protect business confidential information with subcontractors' need to know to contribute to a winning solution and proposal. Steps to address these relationships include:



The proposal manager must be sure that teaming and subcontractor agreements are in place as early as possible to facilitate consistent proposal involvement from teaming partners.

2-2 Encourage the team to attend the pre-proposal conference

Often customers schedule a pre-proposal conference (onsite or virtual) after issuing a bid request, inviting all organizations who have responded to the draft bid request or registered with the customer expressing their interest in bidding.

The customer sometimes gives a short presentation on the opportunity, including clarification of any problem areas that have come up since the bid request was issued. Bidders are then allowed to ask questions about the bid request or the opportunity. The customer often posts these questions, and subsequent responses, so all potential bidders see the information.

Take careful notes, including the answers to key questions you have. Observe and record the reactions of others at the conference. Consider attendance by the program or technical team mandatory.

Customers often limit attendees. If limited to two participants, start with the opportunity manager and a member of the management team.

Carefully consider what questions to ask, how to ask a question, and what your question might reveal to the customer and competitors.

Use the pre-proposal conference to learn more about the procurement. Do not reveal your technical or management approach.

Review the posted or emailed bidder conference notes to identify competitors, potential teaming partners, and potential teaming combinations.

Any customer interaction during the bid or solicitation process is encouraged—especially formal invitations to meet with the customer.

2-3 Impose solution freeze; finalize WBS and WBS dictionary, SOW(s), responsibility matrix, and program schedule; coordinate with the program and pricing teams for the make/buy plan

Shortly after the positive bid validation decision, the core opportunity and proposal teams should implement recommended refinements and freeze the solution so you can focus on preparing a clear, concise, and persuasive proposal. Freeze the solution with firm support of your senior management stakeholder for this pursuit.

Set a design-freeze date, obtain the endorsement of your program champion, enter it on the proposal preparation schedule, and emphasize it at the proposal kickoff meeting and subsequent daily stand-up meetings.

Finalize a WBS dictionary that defines each task and the boundaries between tasks. Fuzzy boundaries lead to confusion, double pricing, or under pricing. The WBS dictionary clarifies program tasks for estimators and the customer. It also helps team members track and report WBS item costs during program development.

If the bid request requires an Integrated Master Plan, Integrated Master Schedule, or Performance Work Statements, align the WBS with these requirements.

Identify, integrate, and manage these tasks by preparing a proposal responsibility matrix. A proposal responsibility matrix links proposal sections, and assists the program team in developing a compliance matrix for the requirements, responsible authors, page limits or guidelines, WBS and SOW items, Contract Line Items, and Contract Data Requirements.

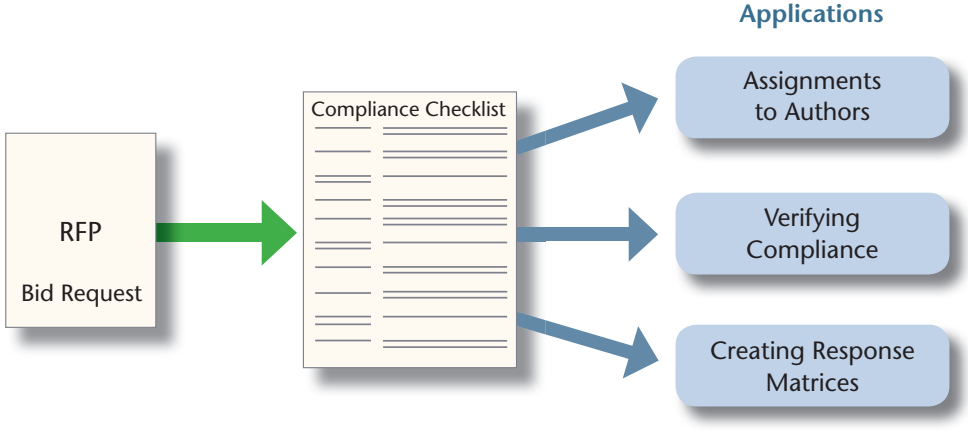


Shipley Proposal Outline and Status Tracker

2-4 Create compliance checklists, proposal response matrix

Carefully read bid request sections and develop a compliance checklist. Compliance checklists help ensure complete responsiveness by identifying each requirement and relating each requirement to the appropriate bid request paragraph.

- ✓ Follow the order of topics and paragraphs in the bid request. Within paragraphs, follow the order of sentences.
- ✓ List each requirement as a separate checklist item. If a sentence or paragraph contains two or more requirements, then list each requirement as a separate item.
- ✓ Use the customer's words and phrases in the checklist. Do NOT paraphrase. Use the customer's language.
- ✓ Begin each item with the action verb used in the bid request, such as identify, list, discuss, show, indicate, demonstrate, and describe. These verbs tell the proposal writer what the customer wants to see in the proposal.
- ✓ Periodically check the proposal content against the checklists to see that every requirement has been met.



Shipley Proposal Outline and Status Tracker

See Compliance and Responsiveness and Outlining in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

2-5 Update and finalize Proposal Management Plan (PMP)

All information relevant to planning, managing, and producing the proposal is part of the PMP. Keep the PMP current to reduce confusion and the need for re-work.

Include the following information when updating the PMP:

- Additional background data on the program, customer, and competition gathered since the preliminary plan was drafted
- Adjusted dates, times, resources, and activities on the schedule
- Specific dates for the various project deadlines; use Gantt charts or calendars to show the project's overall chronology and overlapping functions
- Brief discussions of major milestones and key events, including kickoff meeting, status, and proposal reviews
- Proposal strategy
- Compliance checklists
- Proposal outline
- Individual writing assignments, page limits, and deadlines
- Proposal style sheet, including customer and in-house requirements
- Links or references to supporting documents and plans. Some customer-mandated plans will be required at proposal submittal or by a specified date. Other plans are internal, such as a Negotiation Plan

The proposal manager frequently updates the PMP to provide real-time visibility for the proposal team.

2-6 Hold proposal update kickoff meeting

Kickoff meetings should be motivational, informative, and directive. The proposal manager should run the kickoff meeting, with support from the opportunity or capture manager.

With all bid request information available, a kickoff update meeting is essential. If your opportunity did not have a draft solicitation document or preliminary bid document, then prepare for this kickoff meeting as in step 1-23.

Hold a proposal update kickoff meeting to announce, confirm, and coordinate changes in the following items:

- Proposal strategy and win themes
- Proposal outline
- Page allocations and limits
- Program organization, resumes, and teams
- Costing strategy and estimating guidelines (in conjunction with the cost leader)
- Task descriptions and BOE procedures (in conjunction with the program manager)
- Writer assignments
- Proposal development schedule milestones
- Proposal operations
- Teammate or vendor assignments
- File transfers, graphics, and data flow to production
- Security controls
- Editing, proofreading, and publication operations
- Technical or management solutions
- Program selections for past performance
- Re-use or boilerplate material guidelines
- Coordination among writers/volume managers and teammates

Be sure roles, responsibilities, tasks, and milestones are clear to the proposal development team.

See Kickoff Meeting and Virtual Team Management in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

2-7 Finalize/review PDWs and mockups/OPPs in response to customer solicitation

With an updated proposal outline and strategy from the kickoff meeting, direct writers to review and update their PDWs.

When several PDWs link to common topics, ask volume managers or section leaders to facilitate brainstorming sessions to rapidly stimulate new and congruent ideas.

Proposal writers update their PDWs, develop corresponding mockups, and review both with peers. The mockups include headings, theme statements, summaries, introductory bulleted lists of key points, notations indicating a graphic, and the action caption.

Draft the text after the PDW and mockup are approved by the proposal manager.

Some proposal managers expand this review into a Pink Team Update review.

As soon as you know the proposal production requirements, begin planning for production. Procure the necessary supplies (paper, toner, binders, CDs/DVDs, boxes, production facility time and space) and communicate the plan to your team and management.

 See Storyboards and Mockups in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

2-8 Develop proposal visuals and supporting text

Proposal evaluators repeatedly say that they are drawn to the visual elements of a proposal first; then they read the text, if needed, to answer questions and score the response. Ask these questions when developing visuals and their supporting text:

What is the overall point of this section? What exactly are you selling?

What are the central technical ideas? What data and content will support these ideas?

Which medium (words or visuals) will best sell ideas to the customer? How can this content best convey the key selling points?

What visual concept best expresses the central message?

What level of generality or specificity does this section address? Is it presenting an overview discussion or a finely detailed technical subsection?

Is this visual describing complex processes or complicated relationships? Will readers be able to grasp a visual representation better and faster than they could grasp the subject if it were described verbally?

What kinds of visuals will be most effective for the evaluators who will be scoring this section? What kind of visual would compel the evaluators to score this section higher?

Are the captions supportive of the overall win theme and sales message?

Visual Production Control Log

Identify, isolate, and remedy typical writers' problems. Figure 10 below contains several examples.

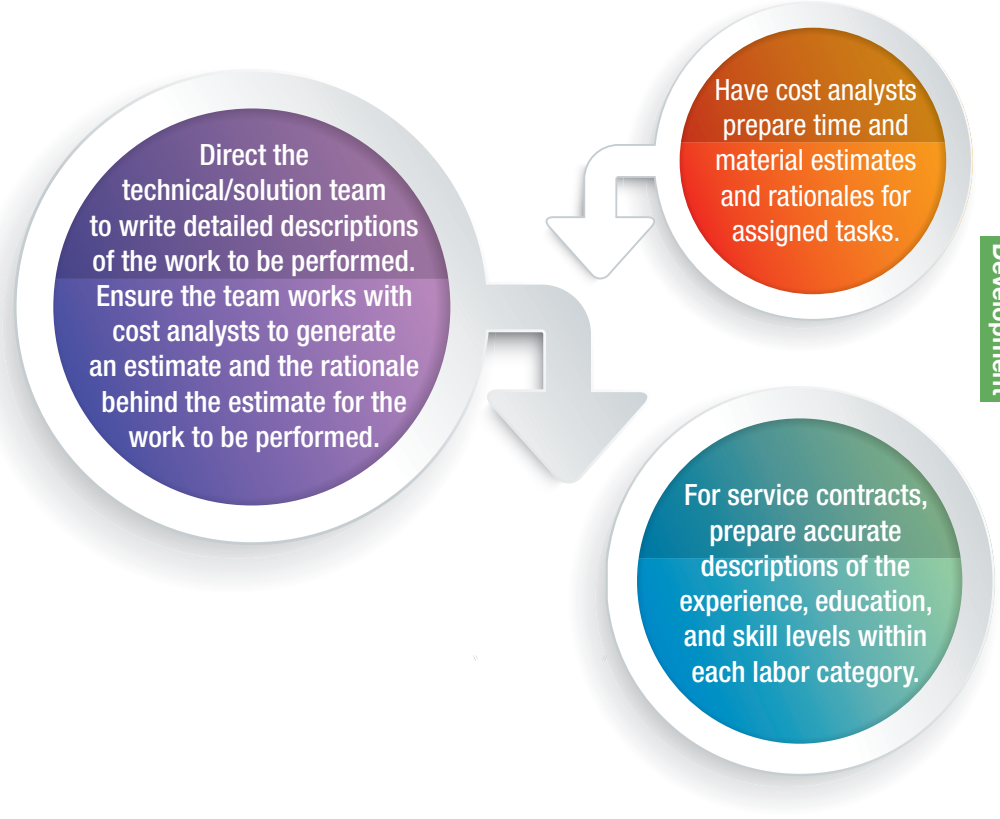
POTENTIAL PROBLEM	POSSIBLE SOLUTION
Some writers can't get started. Perhaps they are not sure what they are going to say, don't clearly understand the task, or the task is so overwhelming that they can't decide where and how to begin.	Brainstorm in a group or individually. Either way, the point is to get as many ideas or concepts written as quickly as possible. Write as fast as possible. Do not judge, edit, or organize.
Some writers lose sight of their goals because they forget the purpose of their writing (or were never given a purpose to begin with). They may write a great deal, but it is an unfocused "dump."	Give writers clear, precise strategies and theme statements derived from your sales and capture activities, to help them focus their sections. Discuss with them how their sections fit into the proposal. Writers need a focused perspective.
Some writers have trouble organizing their thoughts, often because they can't decide what is of primary importance and what is secondary.	Use clustering or outlining techniques to assist writers in prioritizing and organizing their material. Clustering—literally drawing circles connected by lines—works especially well with visually oriented people. The more traditional method of outlining works well with people who feel comfortable with structure and words.
Some writers insert existing material, feeling that it was already written, reviewed, accepted, and submitted before. Why write new material?	Use re-use material to stimulate thinking and identify potentially relevant points. Insist that each requirement be answered succinctly, then adapt the boilerplate to support the summary answer. Emphasize the organization that mirrors the bid request, including only directly relevant material.

Figure 10. Overcoming Challenges to Preparing Proposal Drafts. *A successful proposal manager anticipates protential drafting problems and helps writers overcome these challenges early in the drafting stage.*

Encourage writers to use their storyboards and mockups to reduce revision cycles. Monitor writers' progress daily.

2-9 Write task description estimates and rationales

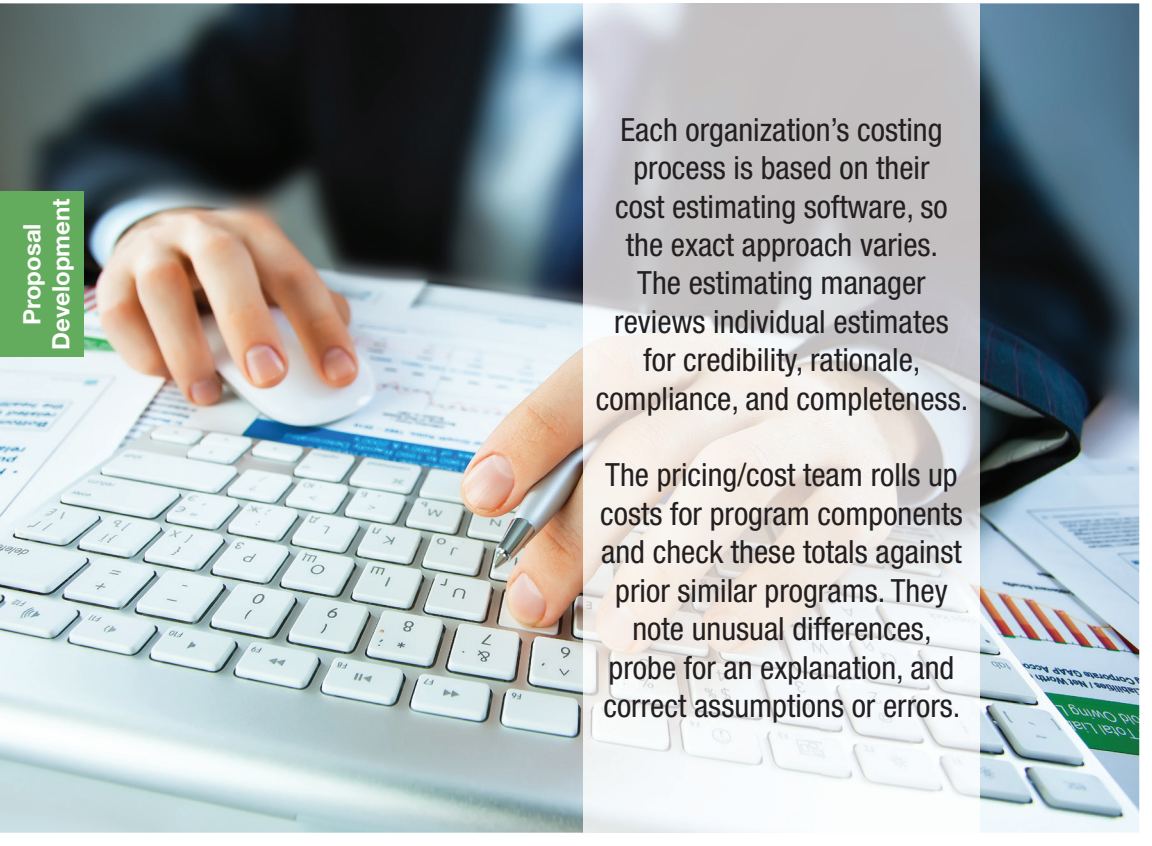
Improve the alignment among technical and management proposal sections and the cost volume.



See Costing in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

2-10 Check on updated costing figures for cost volume

The proposal manager facilitates collaboration between the solution team and the pricing/cost team.



The updates here are added to the cost volume in preparation for the Red Team and Green Team reviews.

2-11 Hold daily status and compliance review meetings

Conduct status and compliance meetings every morning for a major proposal, or weekly for smaller proposals. Determine who needs to attend based on the size and complexity of the project and the relative experience of team members.

Managing a virtual proposal team, or a team with remote contributors, presents unique challenges. Adapt your management approach when you have remote contributors.

The status meeting should accomplish these objectives:

- ✓ Monitor each volume, section, and subsection
- ✓ Keep team members informed of the project's status
- ✓ Discover problems early in the process
- ✓ Check compliance with organization and customer requirements

The proposal manager must keep the team informed on a daily basis. Co-located proposal teams can meet face-to-face. Virtual teams can leverage technology. The key is regular, consistent, and exact communication.

See Daily Team Management and Virtual Team Management in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

2-12 Review drafts and visuals

Regularly review progress on proposal section drafts and oral presentation drafts to help ensure consistency with other sections, responsiveness, strategy implementation effectiveness, clear communication, and persuasive messages.

1

Assign review dates in the project plan. Review dates are crucial to keeping the project on schedule. If one small subsection is incomplete or missing, the entire section is defective.

2

Make comments constructive, clear, and positive. Assign people to review drafts and visuals. Reviewers may be section leaders on major projects or contributors on medium to small projects.

3

For oral presentation drafts, place equal emphasis on the visual/content elements and the presentation elements. A common mistake is to spend 90 percent on the content and 10 percent on the presentation.

Orchestrate the presentation, train and coach presenters, and rehearse repeatedly in an environment that simulates the anticipated presentation environment. Anticipate difficult questions, prepare responses, and rehearse responders.

2-13 Prepare proposal drafts and costs for Red Team and Green Team (as appropriate) reviews

To prepare for the critical Red Team and Green Team reviews, the proposal manager oversees content development for all submittal documentation, including cost documentation. The proposal manager (and volume leads, if on your team) should review the proposal volumes and sections; direct revisions and edits, as necessary; and approve them for Red Team and Green Team use. The proposal manager directs publication of the content so the copy can be produced for final review.

Since organizations vary in their review processes, the Red Team and Green Team reviews may be conducted separately or as part of the same review. Either is acceptable.

As proposal manager, be prepared to facilitate these reviews or work with a designated facilitator for each review. Deliver the full proposal content and the customer's evaluation factors to the reviewers prior to the Red Team. In your role as proposal manager, you may brief the reviewers and have all proposal materials available to answer reviewer questions.

To prepare for the critical Red Team and Green Team reviews, the proposal manager oversees content development for all submittal documentation, including cost documentation.

The volume leaders and proposal manager should review the proposal sections; direct revisions and edits, as necessary; and approve them for Red Team and Green Team use. The proposal manager directs publication of the content so the copy can be produced for final review.

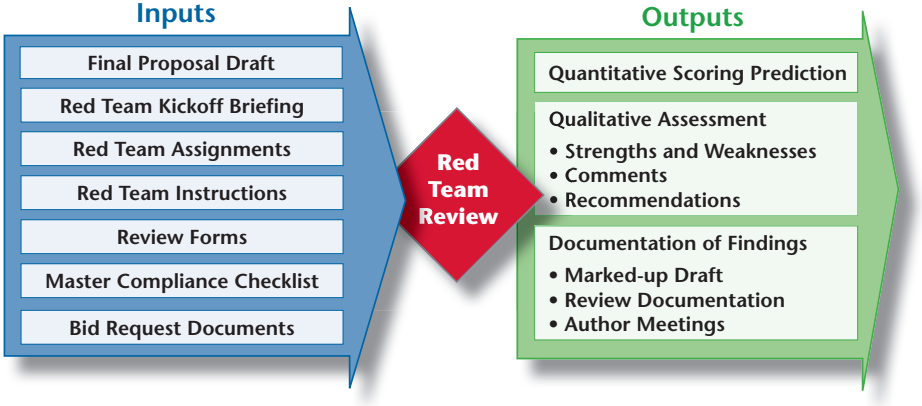
The proposal manager may facilitate these reviews. Expect to brief the reviewers and have all proposal planning materials available. When consultants and subcontractors are involved, management is often reluctant to share pricing information. Cost reviewers might need to be entirely different from the reviewers of other volumes.

2-14 Hold Red Team review

The Red Team predicts how well your proposal will score against customer evaluation criteria and recommends improvements. It evaluates your near-final proposal for customer focus, completeness, and clear communication of your solution set and win strategy. Red Team is a document review and should come early enough to allow coordinated changes to be made to all sections and volumes of the proposal.

At a high level, the Red Team review addresses the following questions:

- What is the overall message effect of the proposal? Does it sell? Does it represent us in the best possible manner?
- Is the proposal customer focused? Does it clearly and consistently project the proposal strategy?
- Are theme statements and headings used effectively?
- How responsive is the proposal to all bid request and administrative requirements?
- Are discriminators used to highlight our strengths and competitors' weaknesses, mitigate our weaknesses, and neutralize competitors' strengths?
- Are features linked to benefits, preferably with the benefits stated first?
- Is the proposal organization consistent with what the customer requires?
- Are emphasis devices (headings, lists, white space) used effectively?
- Are graphics used effectively?
- Is the writing style crisp and clear? Are verbs active rather than passive?
- Is the proposal attractively packaged (cover letter, binding, reproduction)?



Red Team Assignments and Summary
Red Team Instructions
Red Team Planner
Red Team Review Form
Red Team In-briefing
Red Team Out-briefing
Red Team Review Checklist
Red Team Scoring Guidance
Red Team Horizontal Review

The horizontal review team for themes reworks theme statements. This team asks:

- Do themes sell by linking features to benefits?
- Do selected themes identify the customer and us?
- Are themes as specific as the occasion will allow?

The horizontal review team for visuals reworks the visuals and action captions. This team asks:

- Are the visuals complete?
- Can they stand alone?
- Are they cluttered?
- Would a multi-frame visual work better?
- Do the captions interpret, sell, and lead the evaluator to the proper conclusion?
- Are long fold-outs minimized?
- Are visuals vertical rather than horizontal, introduced in prior text, and numbered correctly and sequentially?

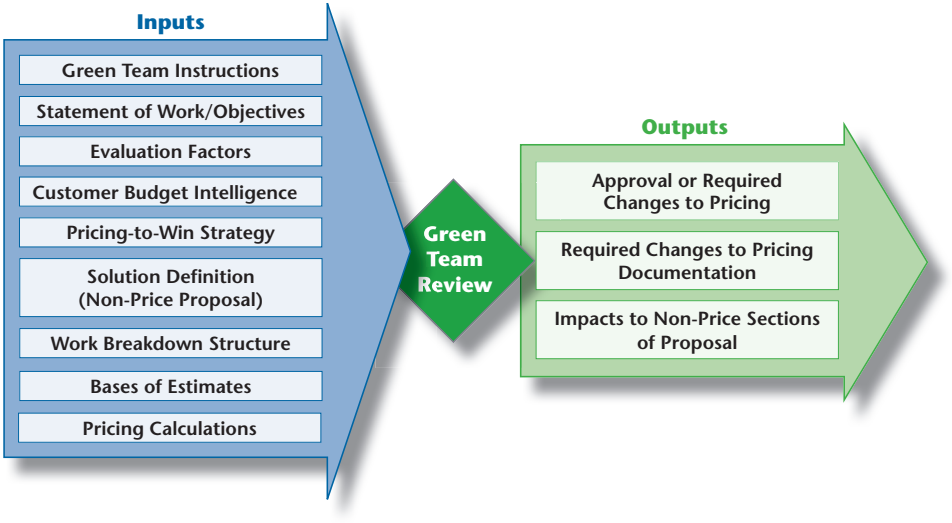
The vertical review team for text reworks the text, ignoring the themes and the visuals. This team asks:

- Is the text well-organized, using an organizational approach?
- Are section introductions reflected in sub-headings?
- Is the writing customer focused? Does the text sell by linking benefits to features, in that order?
- Is plenty of white space used (bulleted lists, one-sentence paragraphs, boxes, changes in type size) to aid the reader and emphasize major points?
- Is the writing clear and consistent?

2-15 Hold Green Team review

A Green Team is an in-house cost review team that compares pricing against the technical, management, and other non-price solution components to confirm everything is included in the estimate. At a high level, the Green Team review addresses the following questions:

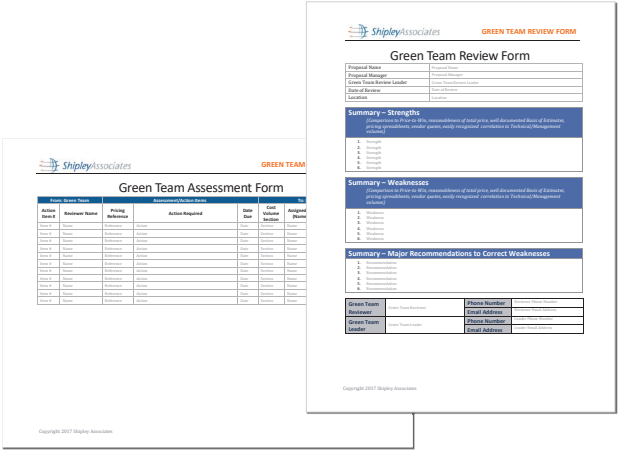
- Are we in line with the customer's budget?
- Are we compatible with the customer's procurement history (low price, best value, etc.)?
- Have we taken into consideration the competitors' likely pricing strategies?
- Are our BOEs for this bid based on our final solution?
- How does risk impact our pricing? Our competitors?
- Are we at a price that beats the competitors?
- Is the final pricing fully reflective of the technical volume and subcontractor WBS?
- Have Red Team changes affected our pricing?
- Will any Green Team changes impact the technical and/or management volumes?
- Could we deliver the work profitably at this price?



Green Team Planner
Green Team Instructions
Green Team Assessment Form
Green Team Review Form

After the Red Team and Green Team reviews, decide what recommendations will be accepted, specify the change, and determine who will make the proposal revision.

Track change requirements and recommendations individually, and update your tracking when each requirement or recommendation is completed. The section writers typically revise their text as necessary, editors re-edit the revised drafts, and desktop publishers finalize the formatting for compliance and readability. The final documents are then submitted for final review and production.



2-16 Conduct final compliance check and publish proposal deliverables

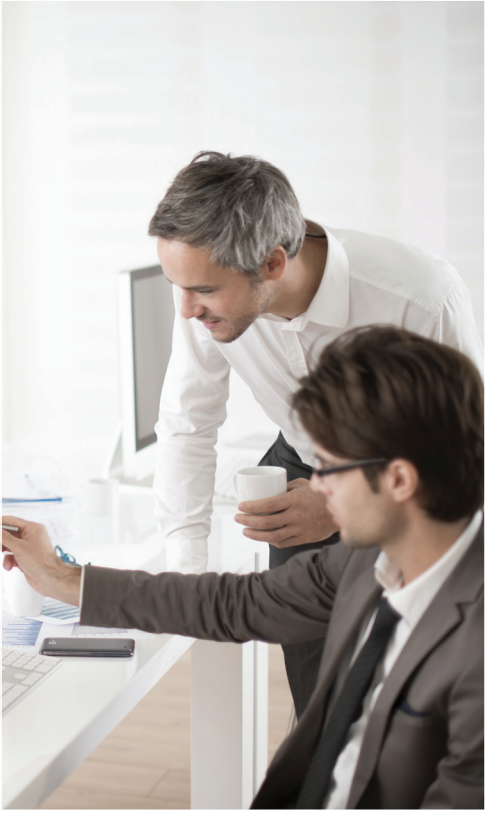
In the proposal schedule, allow sufficient time prior to proposal delivery for final production activities, including editing, desktop publishing, hyperlinking, and creating the final delivery package. The proposal manager directs a thorough compliance check against all customer requirements.

Proposal Development

The core proposal team should check the compliance of the entire proposal. Use the compliance checklist and cross-reference matrix to verify 100 percent compliance unless you have deliberately opted to submit a non-compliant solution.

If submitting hard-copy versions of your proposal, conduct a “page-turn” review after final production and assembly to determine if any pages need correction or did not print.

With electronic submissions increasingly becoming the norm, complete similar checks and processes before uploading to FTP sites.



Develop the final materials for a final management review prior to submission.

Final Production Instructions

2-17 Conduct final legal, cost, and management reviews; hold Gold Team review

One final review by key stakeholders verifies readiness for proposal submission. The proposal manager coordinates the review by the legal, cost, contracting, or other management functions, but typically does not participate in those reviews. At this stage, only changes that are absolutely necessary should be allowed. The proposal manager does facilitate the Gold Team review.



The Gold Team reviews the final version of the proposal. It confirms improvements recommended by Red and Green Teams have been incorporated. It verifies proposal document quality and conformance to organizational standards.

In summary, the Gold Team determines whether the sales document is ready for the Proposal Submittal decision, where the executive leadership gives final authorization to deliver the proposal to the customer. A properly conducted Gold Team lets the executive leadership focus on the deal at the decision gate rather than the document.

Executive or leadership approval before final submittal is essential.

2-18 Submit Proposal

Submit the proposal on time. Plan a backup delivery method in case something goes awry.

For electronic submissions, have an IT expert available to help with potential transmission glitches. Get a time stamp on electronic submittals.

When using couriers, insist on a receipt of delivery with a time stamp. Couriers will get these for you if asked. When delivering in person, have a receipt made that the receiving individual can sign.

Always make sure you receive confirmation from your customer that they received the proposal.

Post-Submittal Activities

Having expended 85 percent of the pursuit costs before proposal submittal, advance the sale by immediately focusing on post-submittal activities.

Develop discussion and pricing strategies that reinforce your strengths and mitigate your weaknesses.



Notes:

3.0 Post-Submittal Activities

Post-submittal activities are about closing the sale as rapidly as possible so you can begin converting your business development success into revenue and bottom-line profit.

Focus on four key post-submittal activities:

1. Clarify and resolve open items
2. Conclude contract negotiations
3. Initiate a smooth transition to service delivery
4. Capture lessons learned to improve processes

3-1 Organize and maintain proposal documentation

Collect all relevant materials used to produce the proposal as well as finished copies of the entire proposal. These materials may be needed for the final proposal, negotiations, and post-award delivery activities. Organize materials so they are readily available as you move toward program execution. Figure 11 below shows some of the materials to organize and archive.



Figure 11. Project and Proposal Archives. *Organized, accessible project and proposal archives reduce problems during post-submittal activities, including cost proposal audits. Ideally, sales/capture and proposal leaders and contributors are available, but memories are incomplete, unsupported, and often challenged, so these archived materials are essential to negotiate the contract and minimize your project risk.*

3-2 Conduct a lessons-learned review

Conduct a lessons-learned review to determine how your processes, strategies, and talent can be improved.



Conduct this review as soon as possible after proposal submittal while memories are fresh and before sales/capture and proposal team contributors are unavailable or less interested.

Focus on your internal successes, problems, and improvements.

The proposal manager facilitates a lessons-learned review and documents areas of strength and weakness throughout the proposal effort. Keep this information current and add it to the White Hat review in section 3-8.

Lessons Learned Review Checklist

Lessons Learned Survey

See Color Team Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

3-3 Prepare for oral presentation and Q&A

Many customers conduct discussions with bidders before making a final award decision. These may lead to proposal modifications (called Final Proposal Revisions by the U.S. Government). The strategy for the revision discussion is usually based on three things:

- ✓ Questions and clarifications you received and answered
- ✓ Sense of the proposal's strengths and weaknesses by the oportunity owner, proposal manager, and project manager
- ✓ Intelligence gathered since submitting the proposal (including competitive information)

Overall, the strategy should be fairly simple:

1. To respond fully to customer questions and concerns
2. To reinforce the customer's trust in your solution and organization

Your proposed team must appear to be technically competent and well-managed. Be prepared to explain the cost-estimating methods or cost-accounting techniques, as required.

Refine and reconfirm your strategy before entering discussions.

What questions will the customer ask?

Who on the team will answer which questions?

How should you answer these questions?

What should you emphasize in your responses?

What should you say when you do not have an answer?

What do you want to say regardless of what questions the customer asks?

What do you want to say before—and—after—the meeting?

What shouldn't you say?

What do you want to discover?

How technical should you be?

When customers do not fully understand a proposal, they may communicate with bidders or ask questions. These may be called Errors, Omissions, and Clarifications; Clarification Requests (CRs); Deficiency Reports (DRs); Contractor Inquiries; or Evaluation Notices (ENs). Whatever the name, they stand for the same thing: parts of the proposal that the evaluators do not understand, find confusing, or believe they do not have sufficient information to evaluate accurately.

See Presentations to Customers in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

Customers may communicate in written or oral form. They may ask you to respond in writing, in a presentation, or both.

Treat such questions seriously, and respond in the most appropriate manner with the best information available.

Follow these guidelines:

Log the question as it is received, and forward it to selected members of the program office and proposal project team.

Analyze questions as carefully as the bid request. Respond fully and on time. If questions are long or complicated, create compliance checklists for each one.

Outline your response with a group of relevant core team members, including the section author, volume manager, and technical or management content expert.

If a discussion follows the written responses, keep track of all questions by topic area and **develop an aligned discussion strategy.** The questions indicate where the customer had concerns with the proposal. The same issues are usually raised during discussions.

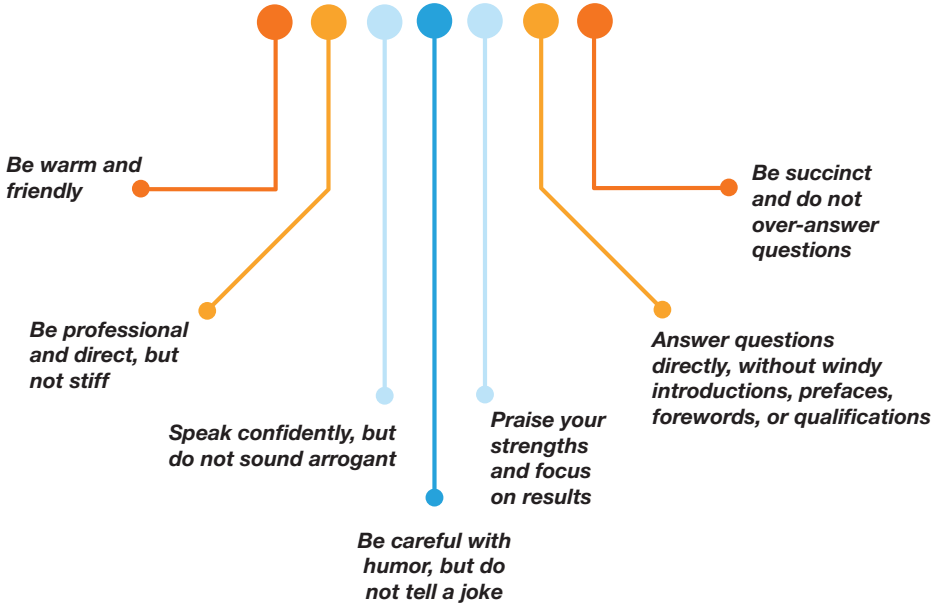
Do not respond by referring the customer to the proposal. Instead, answer the question, confirm that your answer was sufficient, and only then might you refer the customer to proposal content that was difficult to locate.

Maintain a helpful, professional tone in your written and oral responses. Your objective is to enhance your position.

Be sure that the cost volume leader is aware of the technical questions. The technical areas in question may have some bearing on the pricing strategy and could influence the price quoted in any proposal revision. The customer's fact-finding objective is to clarify the proposal, but not to reach an agreement. Fact finding may be done by the customer's cost analyst, field auditors, or technical auditors.

3-4 Participate in discussions, oral presentations, and briefings

Ideally, your proposal secured a contract. But when the customer wants to talk first or have a demonstration, your organization should:



Preparing for oral presentations or demonstrations is a common part of the sales process. Always plan, organize, and deliver your presentation according to customer instructions and underlying motivations and issues. Establish a mock orals review to practice the presentation several times before giving it.

See Oral Proposals in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

3-5 Prepare and approve final proposal, if requested

After reviewing the proposal, the customer often requests a proposal revision from each bidder. Write the revision just as the team wrote the original proposal. Mark each change so that the evaluators can find the changed material easily.

Use the original writers to make the changes if they are qualified, available, and needed. If changes are limited, contributors can often make and consolidate the changes.

Make only those changes that the customer specifically requests. Never make unnecessary changes. Evaluators review only your changes, so changes to other sections will not be considered.

Reconvene the Red Team to review the revisions. Review meticulously because these changes will be carefully reviewed by the customer. This Red Team must make sure that you have responded fully to the customer's questions and have incorporated the desired strategy.

3-6 Prepare and implement project transition plan

Transition plans must be quickly prepared from the baseline of the proposed plan, reflecting new contract requirements.

Typical content of a transition plan includes:

- Planned contract start and end dates
- Deliverables, milestones, due dates, review types and dates, and approval procedures
- If onsite with customer: office fixture inventory, removal, or placement; badging or other access; service connect or disconnect (telephones, copier maintenance, etc.); parking facilities; copies of customer policies regarding proper individual conduct, emergency provisions, inclement weather situations, etc.
- Classified materials inventory and transfer of custody
- Customer contact lists: key personnel, fax numbers, email addresses, working hours, etc.
- Billing formats and deadlines
- Customer accounts receivable contacts
- Databases to be maintained
- Hardware and software to be implemented or maintained, including upgrade and backup considerations
- Scheduling of key personnel (if résumés of key individuals were included in the proposal, their availability should be solidified. You do not want to promise the customer something that you cannot deliver.)
- In-briefings and out-briefings for key personnel (e.g., security officer)

The proposal manager must help transition from proposal submittal to project implementation.

3-7 Request and attend customer debriefing

Win or lose, always request and attend a debriefing by the customer. You have nothing to lose, and you may gain a lot.

Request a debrief to help your organization and team improve future proposals and build a positive relationship with the customer.

If you lost, learn from your mistakes. The same people may evaluate your next proposal, so do not be defensive or argumentative. You probably will not agree with all of their criticisms of your proposal. But remember your role—they are the evaluators, and you are the evaluatee.

Customer debriefs on winning proposals are often the most useful. Hopefully, you will be able to repeat the processes and characteristics that led to the win.

3-8 Conduct a White Hat review

Add the input from your customer debrief to the lessons learned review, and conduct a White Hat. Review from both internal and external perspectives to determine how future pursuits can be more successful. The White Hat review can be a key component of continuous process improvement for your organization's business development operations.

- ☑ Gather information from both internal and external participants in an opportunity pursuit
- ☑ Document things that worked well, and those that did not
- ☑ Develop recommendations, including steps and activities to continue, and methods or approaches to change



White Hat Instructions
White Hat Planner

See Color Team Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

3-9 Celebrate your proposal, win or lose

Winning business solves many business challenges. The proposal manager is a key component to competing and winning.



Post-Submittal Activities

Have a victory party for all individuals who contributed to the proposal. While this step is at the end, many proposal managers hold the first victory party immediately after proposal submittal, and then schedule a second victory party if they win the contract.

Your team has worked hard and put in long hours, often sacrificing personal or family time and responsibilities. Recognize their efforts, accomplishments, and value to your organization. Contributors who feel appreciated are more inclined to support subsequent proposal efforts.

"Good proposal managers are important. Great proposal managers take ownership and lead the organization forward."

—Brad Douglas, CEO, Shipley Associates

Tools and Templates

Referenced Tools

The following tools and templates are referenced in the *Playbook* and are included in the downloadable tools file.

KICKOFF MEETING

- Kickoff Meeting Checklist

PROPOSAL MANAGEMENT, SCHEDULES, AND OUTLINES

- Shipley 30-day blank schedule
- Shipley 45-day blank schedule
- Proposal Outline and Status Tracker

STRATEGY AND SOLUTION DEVELOPMENT

- Bidder Comparison Matrix
- Strategy Statement Template
- Integrated Solution Worksheet
- Shipley Project Basis of Estimate Template

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

- Executive Summary Organizer
- Executive Summary Planning Worksheet

DRAFTING AND WRITING

- Proposal Development Worksheet
- Mockup Template
- Proposal Section Organizer
- Proposal Section Planner
- Orals Development Checklist
- Oral Proposal Planner (OPP)
- Four-Box Organizer

PRODUCTION

- Visuals Production Control Log
- Final Production Instructions

PINK TEAM

- Pink Team Instructions
- Pink Team Planner
- Pink Team Assessment Form
- Pink Team Review Form
- Pink Team In-Briefing Template
- Pink Team Out-Briefing Template

RED TEAM

- Red Team Assignments and Summary
- Red Team Instructions
- Red Team Planner
- Red Team Review Checklist
- Red Team Scoring Guidance Form
- Red Team Review Form
- Red Team Horizontal Review Form
- Red Team In-briefing Template
- Red Team Out-briefing Template

GREEN TEAM

- Green Team Planner
- Green Team Instructions
- Green Team Assessment Form
- Green Team Review Form

WHITE HAT (LESSONS LEARNED)

- Lessons Learned Review Checklist
- Lessons Learned Survey
- White Hat Instructions
- White Hat Planner

Proposal Checklist: *Proposal Planning*

- ❑ Continue customer contacts from the Opportunity or Capture Plan
- ❑ Develop proposal strategy
- ❑ Define proposal tasks, budget, and schedule
- ❑ Review and approve proposal strategy, pricing, and cost
- ❑ Establish team area and library
- ❑ Develop a draft WBS and WBS Dictionary
- ❑ Receive the program/project schedule from the program or technical team
- ❑ Initiate detailed make/buy plan
- ❑ Validate that in-house, subcontractor, and/or teaming Statements of Work (SOWs) are being developed by your company
- ❑ Develop initial proposal outline
- ❑ Establish a Proposal Management Plan (PMP)
- ❑ Support customer definition of needs and requirements
- ❑ Define detailed baseline offering
- ❑ Receive, review, and comment on preliminary solicitation
- ❑ Update winning price window
- ❑ Check with the cost team to track cost drivers and their update of the target price in competitive range
- ❑ Identify writing and reviewing assignments for proposal team members
- ❑ Initiate preparation of storyboards or Proposal Development Worksheets (PDWs)
- ❑ Prepare estimating guidelines
- ❑ Create a SOW/WBS/BOE responsibility matrix
- ❑ Prepare writers' packages and direct the gathering of re-use or boilerplate materials

- ❑ Draft an executive summary
- ❑ Hold proposal kickoff meeting
- ❑ Complete and review storyboards; prepare mockups/Oral Proposal Planners (OPPs)
- ❑ Hold peer review and prepare materials for Pink Team
- ❑ Hold Pink Team review, including cost volume and initial bottom-up cost estimate
- ❑ Update PDWs/storyboards and mockups/OPPs in response to Pink Team
- ❑ Begin early draft content
- ❑ Receive and analyze customer solicitation
- ❑ Prepare final bid/no-bid recommendation
- ❑ Review and validate the bid decision

Proposal Checklist: *Proposal Development*

- ❑ Finalize team and subcontractor relationships
- ❑ Encourage the team to attend the pre-proposal conference
- ❑ Impose solution freeze; finalize WBS and WBS dictionary, SOW(s), responsibility matrix, and program schedule; coordinate with the program and pricing teams for the make/buy plan
- ❑ Create compliance checklists, proposal response matrix
- ❑ Update and finalize Proposal Management Plan (PMP)
- ❑ Hold proposal update kickoff meeting
- ❑ Finalize/review PDWs and mockups/OPPs in response to customer solicitation
- ❑ Develop proposal visuals and supporting text
- ❑ Write task descriptions estimates and rationales
- ❑ Check on updated costing figures for cost volume
- ❑ Hold daily status and compliance review meetings
- ❑ Review drafts and visuals
- ❑ Prepare proposal drafts and costs for Red Team and Green Team (as appropriate) reviews
- ❑ Hold Red Team review
- ❑ Hold Green Team review
- ❑ Conduct final compliance check and publish proposal deliverables
- ❑ Conduct final legal, cost, and management reviews; hold Gold Team review
- ❑ Submit Proposal

Proposal Checklist: *Post-Submittal Activities*

- ❑ Organize and maintain proposal documentation
- ❑ Conduct a lessons-learned review
- ❑ Prepare for oral presentation and Q&A
- ❑ Participate in discussions, oral presentations, and briefings
- ❑ Prepare and approve final proposal, if requested
- ❑ Prepare and implement project transition plan
- ❑ Request and attend customer debriefing
- ❑ Conduct a White Hat review
- ❑ Celebrate your proposal, win or lose



Glossary of Terms

TERM	DESCRIPTION
Bid Request	A generic term for a potential customer's invitation extended to vendors to bid on services or products. A bid request is often referred to as a solicitation.
Boilerplate	A term used for proposal content that can be re-used on current or future proposals – often referred to as re-use content.
Capture	Any activity prior to the issuance of a bid request that seeks to position your organization to win competitive business opportunities more effectively, economically, and consistently. Capture activities have the goal of ethically influencing the customer to prefer your organization and solution early and to maintain that preference through selection, award, and delivery.
Capture Manager	Also referred to as opportunity manager, sales lead, or pursuit manager. This person is designated to lead the sales effort on a specific opportunity—often working closely with a proposal manager throughout the process.
Capture Plan	Envision the capture plan as a framework, a series of folders or buckets where you assemble and organize data by topic. As you conduct sales and capture activities, update the content in the folders based on things to do and learn about the sales environment.
Compliance	Compliance means strict adherence to the customer's bid request, both the submittal instructions and the requirements. Compliance with instructions means that you have followed the requested format, answered all questions, completed all forms, and submitted your response to the right person and place on time. Compliance with requirements means that you have agreed to meet all requirements as asked in the bid request.
Compliance Checklist	A tool to capture all requirements in the solicitation that must be addressed in the proposal.
Customer	The target of your sales messages and recipient of your proposal or solicitation response.
Decision Gate	Key milestones in the business development process, triggered by pre-defined customer actions (such as issuance of a bid request), at which time senior management decides whether to continue the pursuit and invest in competing or end the pursuit.
Discriminator	Feature of your solution that is important to the customer, valueable to the customer, and unique to your company.
Green Team	A review scheduled concurrent with the Red Team review where reviewers validate the Work Breakdown Structure, Basis of Estimate, and final pricing.
Gold Team	A final review scheduled prior to submitting the final proposal to your customer. The Gold Team confirms that your offer entails acceptable profit and risk; they rarely look at the presentation of the document.

TERM	DESCRIPTION
Hot Buttons	A consolidated set of customer issues and motivators for issuing a request for bid. Issues are the customer's concerns or worry items. Motivators are the objectives that the customer is trying to achieve. Hot buttons are typically a subset of both these groupings.
Mockup	A page-by-page layout of each proposal section showing page allocations for each section. The mockup is a visual view of how the section will look on each page. Mockups contain the same elements as the draft, namely, headings, themes, visuals and their captions, and text.
OPP	The Oral Proposal Planner is a tool to help proposal managers plan and organize a sales briefing or oral proposal that aligns with the written proposal.
PDW	Proposal Development Worksheet, is a Microsoft® tool that can be used as a storyboard to map out proposal sections before drafting text.
Pink Team	A review scheduled early in the proposal development process where reviewers validate the implementation of your proposal strategy and verify compliance with the bid request. The Pink Team reviews storyboards, mockups, or writing plans and makes suggestions on content correction.
PMP	The Proposal Management Plan is typically a series of documents or files shared with the proposal team that communicates roles and responsibilities, tasks, outlines, deadlines, and proposal strategy before writers start developing the proposal. PMP contents are updated as needed.
Pwin	Probability of Win. Pwin is a representative number or percentage based on win factor ratings that help determine the likelihood of winning a specific business opportunity. Pwin is used in conjunction with other means of research and analysis to evaluate business opportunities and include an assessment of the competitive position.
Red Team	A review scheduled later in the proposal development process, after a near-final draft is produced, where reviewers evaluate the proposal for customer focus, completeness, and clear communication of your win strategy and solution. Allow enough time after this review for the proposal team to make adjustments and corrections based on Red Team comments.
Response Matrix	This matrix aligns with the compliance matrix and tracks where the proposal response addresses each compliance requirement.
Responsiveness	Responsiveness means addressing the customer's underlying needs. Proposals can be responsive but not compliant, or compliant but non-responsive. The proposal cannot simply agree to meet the requirements in the solicitation. The bid must be specific in describing "how" the requirement will be met. It must also address the needs of the customer and provide specific benefits that are associated with the features of the proposed solution.
RFP/RFQ	Request for Proposal/Request for Quote. Terms used for bid request or solicitation. Non-U.S. bid requests are often referred to as Tenders.
Solicitation	A generic term for the bid request, Request for Proposal, grant request, or any guidance document or information on how to bid for work with a customer.

TERM	DESCRIPTION
SOW	Statement of Work. A document outlining and describing the work to be completed by the vendor as part of the contract.
Storyboard	A conceptual planning tool to help writers plan each section before drafting text. Storyboards contain space to identify bid request requirements, strategies, win themes, preliminary visuals, and suggested content for the section.
Themes	In proposals, themes link a customer benefit to the discriminating features of your offer. Themes tell readers why they should select you. The most powerful themes contain the most important and unique discriminators, something the customer wants that no one else offers.
WBS/WBS Dictionary	Work Breakdown Structure. "A hierarchical decomposition of the total scope of work to be carried out by the project team to accomplish the project objectives and create the required deliverables" *(Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBOK 5)).*
White Hat	A review that documents lessons learned from the capture and proposal efforts to improve future pursuits. Lessons learned come from both internal sources (how did things go and what can we do better) as well as external sources (customer feedback on the proposal and/or teaming partner feedback).
Win Strategy	Overarching themes that apply to the entire proposal. A term used to articulate why your offer is better than the competitors' offers, as perceived by the customer. Defining win strategy involves leveraging your strengths, mitigating your weaknesses, and minimizing your competitors' strengths.

Notes:

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ShipleyAssociates®

About Shipley

Since 1972, Shipley Associates has provided organizations and individuals with business development services focused on winning business in highly competitive environments. With over 200 consultants worldwide, Shipley supports major business development projects from strategy development, capture planning, proposal development, process improvement, and web-based and classroom learning—resulting in an average client win rate of over 82 percent.

Shipley has international offices in over 12 countries. For more information, visit our website www.shipleywins.com.



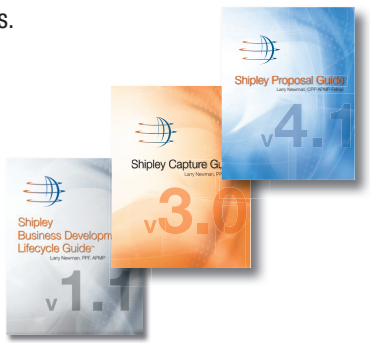
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The Shipley Business Development Series

The *Shipley Proposal Guide* contains 52 topics and 12 model documents. Each topic section provides a summary of key points.

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